



ECONOMIC SURVEY
**'Per capita income of
 Delhi to grow at 7.09%'**
CITY » PAGE 2

WORLD TB DAY

***Pushing back
against TB***

***A curated set of articles on
eliminating the epidemic***



‘ORANGE ECONOMY’
**Centre unveils plans to
 boost creative economy**
NEWS » PAGE 14

Trump pauses strikes on Iran, says deal is possible

Attacks on power infrastructure in Iran will be 'postponed' for five days, says U.S. President; major 'points of agreement' reached in 'good and productive talks,' he says; Iran rejects Trump's claims

Stanly Johnny

U.S. President Donald Trump, who issued a 48-hour ultimatum to Iran on Saturday to reopen the Strait of Hormuz or face strikes on its power infrastructure, said on Monday that he would postpone the attacks for five days after “very good and productive” talks with Tehran.

"I am please[d] to report that the United States of America and the country of Iran have had, over the last two days, very good and productive conversations regarding a complete and total resolution of our hostilities in the Middle East," Mr. Trump wrote in a social media post.

Later in Washington, Mr. Trump told pressper-



Taking hits: A residential building damaged by a strike, amid the U.S.-Israeli conflict with Iran, in Tehran on Monday. REUTERS

Two more Indian vessels cross Strait of Hormuz

CHENNAI
Two Indian-flagged LPG carriers, *Jag Vasant* and *Pine Gas*, have transited through the Strait of Hormuz on Monday evening. They are together carrying nearly 93,000 tonne of LPG, as per the inter-Ministerial briefing held on Monday. » **PAGE 12**

launched a new wave of missile and drone attacks targeting the U.S. Fifth Fleet in Bahrain and U.S. bases in other West Asian countries.

CONTINUED ON
» **PAGE 12**
LONG-TERM IMPACT: PM
» **PAGE 12**

nied negotiations with the U.S., saying that “fake news is intended to... escape the quagmire in which America and Israel are trapped”.

Iranian Foreign Ministry also denied Mr. Trump's claims while the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) said it

Centre signals early delimitation, women's quota for 2029 polls

Nistula Hebbar
NEW DELHI



The Bill will enable delimitation based on the 2011 Census to implement the 2023 quota Act.

The Union government has indicated that it will bring an amendment Bill proposing a delimitation exercise based on the 2011 Census to ensure the implementation of the Women's Reservation Act, 2023, ahead of the 2029 Lok Sabha election.

Under the proposed amendments, the number of Lok Sabha seats will increase from 543 to 816, with 273 seats, 33%, reserved for women. The amendments could be brought in the ongoing Budget Session or in a Special Session called for the purpose.

States' concern

Though the draft of the amendments are yet to be circulated, it is understood by sources that care would be taken so that the existing proportion of seats will

be maintained for all States, amid concerns that States that had showed success in population control programmes would lose out on representation *vis a vis* more populous States. Southern States had in particular expressed this concern. Overall, each State is likely to see a 50% rise in seats, but the pro-rata basis would be maintained.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 12

 **kotak**
Kotak Mahindra Bank

Threatened with a “Digital Arrest”?

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- ▶ Never share any personal or bank details, OTP, PIN or passwords

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This is an AI-generated image. Any resemblance to real persons is purely coincidental.

Rahul criticises use of the term ‘vanvasi’, reiterates call for a caste census

Congress leader says the name used by BJP and RSS reduces tribals to mere forest dwellers whereas the term 'Adivasi' recognises their right over water, forests and land; criticises India-U.S. trade pact

Abhinav Deshpande
AHMEDABAD

Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi on Monday criticised the use of the term ‘vanvasi’ (forest dwellers) by the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) and its political arm, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), for tribal communities, alleging that it diluted their historical rights over land and natural resources.

Speaking at an ‘Adivasi Adhikar Samvidhan Sammelan’ in Vadodara, Mr. Gandhi said the term ‘Adivasi’ denotes original inhabitants, while ‘vanvasi’ suggests that tribals are only forest dwellers. “The term ‘vanvasi’ implies you are not the original owners of this land, whereas ‘Adivasi’ recognises your rights over water, forests and land,” he said. “If you had come here thousands of years ago, every inch of land would have been with Adivasis,” he added.

Describing tribals as ‘vanvasi’ amounted to an attack on the Constitution and the legacy of tribal leader Birsa Munda, Mr. Gandhi alleged. “When tribals are called ‘vanvasi’ and their resources are handed over, it is an attack on the Constitution,” the Congress leader said.

Targeting the BJP and



Congress leader Rahul Gandhi being welcomed during the Adivasi Adhikar Samvidhan Sammelan in Vadodara on Monday. ANI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi, he said the government was not safeguarding tribal rights. “When development is discussed, Adivasi land is taken away, often without compensation, as you are considered to have no rights,” he said.

Land rights “Whenever the subject of development comes up, land belonging to Adivasis is snatched, often without paying compensation as you are deemed to possess no rights, no entitlements whatsoever,” Mr. Gandhi said.

Reiterating his demand for a caste census, Mr. Gandhi said it was necessary to determine the share of various communities in national resources and institutions. “A caste census will show the actual population of Adivasis and

their share in power and wealth,” he said.

Greater representation He also called for greater representation of tribals in institutions, including the bureaucracy, police, and the judiciary.

Adivasis account for 9% of the population while Scheduled Castes constitute 15% and Other Backward Classes account for around 50% of the population, he said.

“Do you believe Adivasis have even a 10% share in the country?” he said, adding that while leaders paid respect to Birsa Munda, there was little action when it came to sharing power and resources.

Adivasis needed greater representation in institutions, Mr. Gandhi said. “Until your people are part of the bureaucracy, police

and judiciary, your interests will not be protected,” he said, alleging that the RSS was influencing these institutions.

On economic issues, Mr. Gandhi criticised India’s trade engagement with the United States, alleging that the agricultural sector had been opened up. “No Prime Minister has opened up agriculture before. If products from large, mechanised farms in the U.S. enter our markets, it will affect Indian farmers,” he said.

“There is a reason for this. Our farms are small, ranging from five to 10 acres. In the U.S., farms span 1,000, 5,000 or even 10,000 acres. Here people work manually and mechanisation is limited; over there, everything is fully mechanised,” he said, adding, “If their produce floods our markets, it will completely ruin our farmers.”

“If we purchase goods worth ₹9 lakh crore from U.S. companies, what will become of our own companies? What will happen to our SMEs (small and medium enterprises)? They have reduced taxes for U.S. products to zero, while simultaneously increasing taxes on our domestic products,” he said.

The Prime Minister is “compromised”, Mr. Gandhi alleged.

Varanasi court rejects bail to 14 people arrested for holding iftar party on Ganga

Press Trust of India
VARANASI

A court in Varanasi on Monday rejected the bail applications of 14 people who were arrested a week ago after they allegedly held an iftar party and ate chicken biryani on a boat in the Ganga river.

The 14 were charged with defiling a place of worship, hurting religious sentiments and causing public nuisance and water pollution. Subsequently, the police had also added a charge regarding the alleged forcible seizure of the boat, according to Shashank Shekhar Tripathi, the counsel for complainant Rajat Jaiswal who is the BJP Yuva Morcha’s city unit chief.

The 14 individuals were booked after a video of the incident surfaced online

“Additional Chief Judicial Magistrate Amit Kumar Yadav observed that the charges are grave and non-bailable; therefore, there are no sufficient grounds to

grant bail at this juncture,” Mr. Tripathi said.

The prosecution strongly opposed the bail application, arguing that the offence committed by the accused is of a serious nature and carries provisions for severe punishment. They also contended that granting bail to the accused could potentially interfere with the judicial process, Mr. Tripathi said.

The 14 individuals were booked after a video of the incident surfaced online last Monday, and a written complaint was filed on the

same day by Mr. Jaiswal. The court had on Thursday sent the 14 people to judicial custody.

According to Mr. Tripathi, the accused had “threatened a boatman and forcibly taken him along before holding the party on his boat in the river”.

The police also submitted a report to the court, citing the boatman’s statement and eyewitness accounts. Consequently, a plea was filed to add several additional charges, including kidnapping.

PIL on transfer of W.B. officials: EC questions locus standi of petitioner

Press Trust of India
KOLKATA

The Election Commission on Monday questioned the locus standi of the petitioner in filing a PIL challenging the transfer of several officers of the West Bengal government after the announcement of Assembly election in the State.

The petitioner, a lawyer, claimed in the PIL that 79 officers - 63 police personnel and 16 civil servants - have been shifted by the EC since the announcement of the Assembly polls on March 15.

The petitioner claimed before a Division Bench presided by Chief Justice Sujoy Paul that the transfers, including that of the Chief Secretary and the Home Secretary, have

created a vacuum in governance in the State.

Senior counsel Kalyan Banerjee, representing the petitioner, claimed that the EC is acting in an arbitrary manner and bringing in officers of its choice before conducting the elections.

Representing the EC, senior advocate DS Naidu stated that the powers of the commission are bound by law and its solemn duty is to conduct free and fair elections. Questioning the maintainability of the petition as a PIL, Mr. Naidu submitted that the petitioner is a full-time State lawyer and thus cannot claim to be a public-spirited person in filing the PIL.

Hearing in the matter was adjourned till Wednesday, when the parties will make further submissions.

Odisha curtails working hours from April 1 as mercury soars

The Hindu Bureau
BHUBANESWAR

The Odisha government on Monday restricted working hours of all government, non-government, industrial establishments and construction sectors from April 1 in view of the rising mercury level.

“All departments of the Odisha government, as well as Central government institutes located in Odisha, private employers, all commercial and industrial establishments, shop owners, business establishments, and contractors are requested to ensure that workers under their supervision are not engaged in work between 11 a.m. and 3 p.m. from April 1 to June 15,” said a notification.

Timings			
DELHI			
TUESDAY, MAR. 24			
RISE	06:21	SET	18:34
RISE	09:49	SET	00:00
WEDNESDAY, MAR. 25			
RISE	06:19	SET	18:35
RISE	10:48	SET	00:38
THURSDAY, MAR. 26			
RISE	06:18	SET	18:36
RISE	11:54	SET	01:40
Delhi Weather			
	max	min	
Delhi City	30	16	
Safdarjang	30	16	
Palam	28	15	

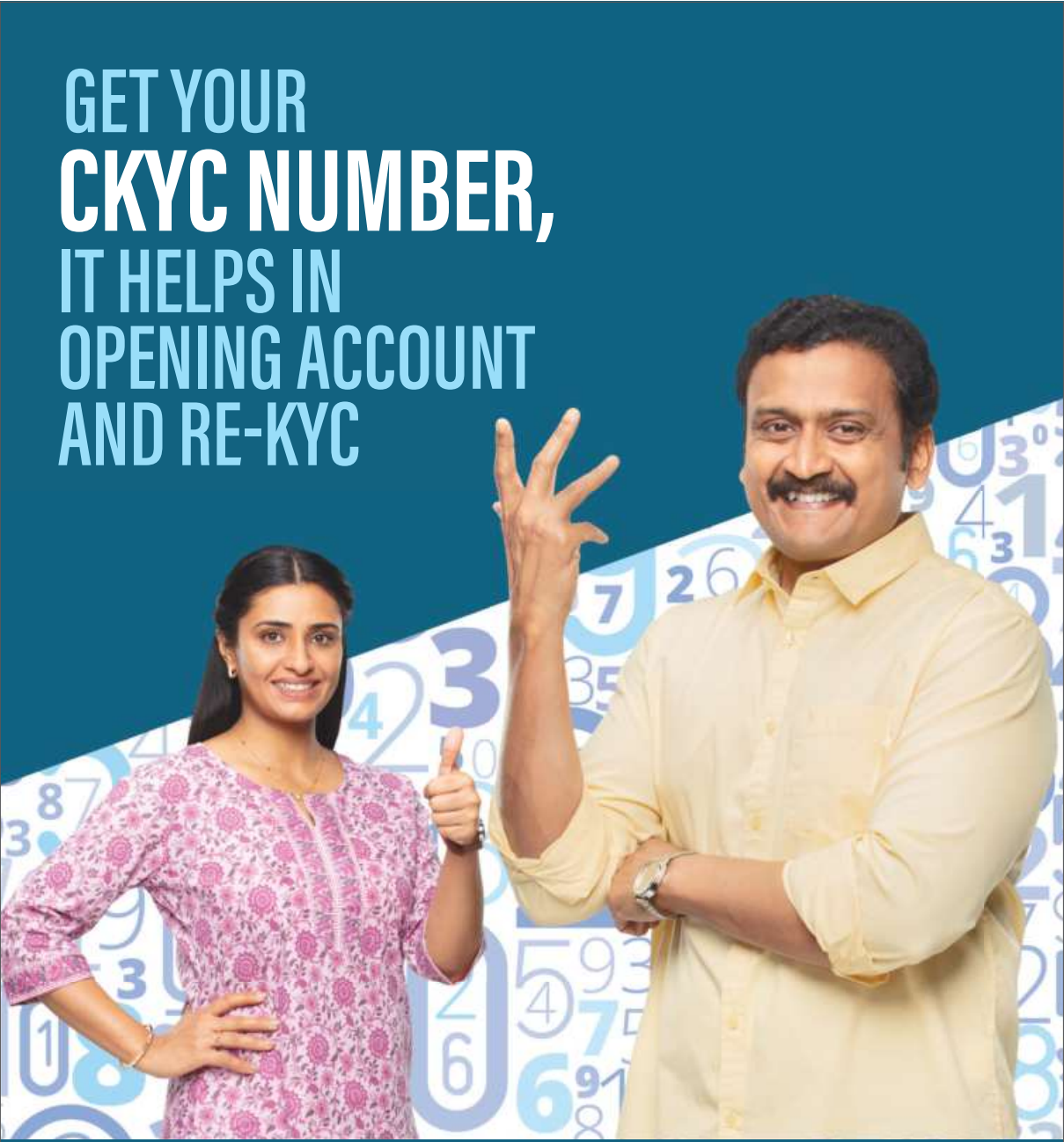
Delhi Palam Today
32°C The weather will be mostly dry. Day will be little warm. Night will be cool.

Delhi Palam Tomorrow
33°C Morning will be cool. Day will be warm. Night also will be cool. Dry weather to occur.

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THE HINDU
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Building Talent That Powers India—Australia’s Global Leadership Ambition

By Professor Iain Martin, Vice-Chancellor, Deakin University

History rarely announces itself. It reveals itself through momentum.

Today, this momentum is reflected in the India-Australia partnership, and progress is both purposeful and enduring. Beyond trade or diplomacy, progress lies in people, in the shaping of talent. And talent, more than any commodity, will determine the trajectory of the Indo-Pacific century.

For decades, the bilateral knowledge collaboration was defined by mobility. Indian students chose Australia for its academic quality and global outlook. They built enduring bridges between our societies, strengthened our economies and deepened our cross-cultural context.

Our nations are richer for it now. But the relationship has matured.

What we are witnessing now is not simply the movement of students, but the mutuality and complementarity of standards, the co-creation of ecosystems and the deliberate building of capability within India itself.

India’s National Education Policy 2020 is one of the most ambitious reform blueprints of our time. It reflects confidence in India’s institutional resilience, in its regulatory evolution, and in its aspiration to emerge as a global knowledge leader. For Deakin, our legacy of engagement with India is a source of great pride, not as an expansion of our footprint, but as a long-term commitment to participating meaningfully in India’s transformational journey.

And responsible participation demands depth.

The future of international education is now defined by effective partnerships that build systems, strengthen local capacity and align learning with national priorities rather than enrolment figures.

The execution and operational delivery of Deakin’s India campus and the successful graduation of its first cohort signals a powerful shift. It is evidence that reform can translate into reality; that global academic standards can be embedded within India’s own innovation architecture; that access to world-class education need not depend on crossing oceans.

Graduation, in this context, is not ceremonial. It is structural. It signals readiness.

Readiness matters because India’s rise is accelerating. Financial services are deepening. Advanced manufacturing is expanding. Artificial intelligence, cybersecurity, clean energy and digital infrastructure are transforming entire sectors. The ambition of ‘Viksit Bharat 2047’ warrants a synergy of skills with scale.

Degrees do more than certify knowledge. They now cultivate capability. This is where the India–Australia partnership finds its most compelling expression.

Australia’s higher education system has long emphasised industry integration, applied research and experiential learning. India brings extraordinary

demographic scale, entrepreneurial dynamism and reform momentum. When these strengths converge, education becomes not an adjunct to economic growth but its driver.

‘The future productivity imperative will be shaped not by scale alone, but by capability and the partnerships that co-create it.’

In hubs such as GIFT City, a bold experiment in regulatory and financial innovation, the industry interfacing is immediate and tangible. Students do not study in isolation from the economy; they study within it. Deakin’s curriculum, internships and capstone projects intersect directly with sectoral priorities. Learning trains not merely for understanding, but for performance in India and on the global stage.

The Deakin University GIFT City Campus model enables India to retain globally competent graduates aligned to national priorities, and Australia to strengthen its strategic engagement while co-nurturing professionals that can rise to domestic and global industry complexities.

This shared endeavour today is the foundation for global leadership tomorrow.

The Indo-Pacific is no longer an emerging construct. With increasing geopolitical influence, it will increasingly define global norms. From digital governance and climate resilience to fintech regulation and ethical artificial intelligence, partnerships in this region with mature institutional systems are uniquely placed to contribute to this agenda.

Transnational education must now invest in local capacity, align with reform ambitions and operate transparently within national frameworks.

Graduation is the evidence of sustained commitment, because the true measure of the India–Australia knowledge corridor lies not in campuses established or agreements signed, but in the confidence, competence and character of the graduates it shapes. They embody the success of a partnership.

As Vice-Chancellor, I see this not simply as an institutional strategy, but a stewardship of standards. Of opportunity. Of aspiration.

India and Australia are well placed in trust, mutuality and complementarity to build a partnership for sustained mileage, and if we deepen it with conviction, we will not merely respond to the Indo-Pacific century. We will help define it.

Professor Iain Martin

INBRIEF



Four dead, 12 injured in cold storage collapse in Prayagraj

Four labourers were killed, and 12 were injured after being trapped under the debris following the collapse of a cold storage facility on Monday afternoon in Prayagraj, an officer said. Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath expressed grief over the incident and have announced financial assistance. DCP (Ganga Nagar) Kuldeep Gunawat said that the cold storage facility, located in the Phaphamau police station area, suddenly crumbled and collapsed. The incident triggered panic in the area as ammonia gas began leaking from the facility. PTI

BJP, Congress, AAP candidates file nomination for Goa bypoll

Candidates from the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) as well as the Opposition Congress and the Aam Aadmi Party filed their nominations on Monday for the upcoming Ponda Assembly byelection in Goa. The BJP has fielded Ritesh Naik, the Congress has given ticket to Ketan Bhatikar, while the AAP has nominated Gitesh Naik for the April 9 bypoll. The bypoll was necessitated due to the death of sitting BJP MLA and then Agriculture Minister Ravi Naik. The BJP has fielded his son for the seat. Chief Minister Pramod Sawant and some members of his Cabinet accompanied Mr. Ritesh Naik as he filed his nomination papers. PTI

Former AAP Minister’s arrest in Punjab triggers credit war among parties

Laljit Singh Bhullar will be produced in a court today in connection with Gagandeep Randhawa’s death last week; ruling party calls arrest ‘swift action’, Opposition parties say govt. ‘forced to act’

The Hindu Bureau
CHANDIGARH

Laljit Singh Bhullar, recently removed as Minister in the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) government in Punjab, was arrested on Monday in connection with the death of a State warehousing corporation official last week. He was arrested from Mandi Gobindgarh in Fatehgarh Sahib district and will be produced in a court on Tuesday, Amritsar Police Commissioner Gurpreet Singh told media persons in Amritsar.

Gagandeep Singh Randhawa, district manager of the Punjab Warehousing Corporation in Amritsar, allegedly died by suicide on Saturday. In a purported video linked to the incident, he had accused Mr. Bhullar of harassing him by pressuring to award a tender to the former Minister’s aide.

Opposition parties in Punjab asserted that the arrest came following the pressure built by them on the AAP government, even



BJP workers protesting against the AAP-led Punjab govt. over the alleged suicide by a govt. employee, in Amritsar on Monday. PTI

as the ruling party claimed credit for acting against its own Minister in the interest of justice.

Leader of the Opposition Partap Singh Bajwa (Congress) said the AAP government had been “forced to climb down from the high horse it was riding” and arrest its own former Minister following sustained pressure from the Opposition.

Mr. Bajwa claimed that action against the former Minister came only after Union Home Minister Amit Shah indicated that a Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) inquiry would be or-

dered into the matter. He said Congress MPs Charanjit Singh Channi, Sukhjinder Singh Randhawa, Gurjeet Singh Aujla and Dharamvira Gandhi forcefully raised the issue in Parliament.

BJP protests

Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) workers and leaders staged protests at several district headquarters in Punjab, demanding that the investigation against Mr. Bhullar be handed over to the CBI. BJP State president Sunil Jakhar alleged, “The AAP government does not want the case to go to the CBI be-

cause if that happens, several layers involving AAP leaders, including those from Delhi, would be exposed, and it would reveal where the money collected by Ministers like Mr. Bhullar was being sent.”

Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) leader Bikram Singh Majithia, meanwhile, demanded that the post-mortem of Randhawa should be conducted at the Post Graduate Institute of Medical Education and Research in Chandigarh or by a panel of All India Institute of Medical Sciences doctors to ensure fair play.

AAP national convener Arvind Kejriwal, in a post on ‘X’, said, “Recently, serious allegations were made against a Minister in the AAP government in Punjab. Our government took immediate action against that Minister without any delay or discrimination, not only removing him from his position but also getting him arrested.”

(Those in distress can dial Tele MANAS helpline at 14416)

Garo district council bars non-tribals from contesting polls after over seven decades

Press Trust of India
SHILLONG

Amidst protests over non-tribal participation in a tribal council election in Meghalaya, the Garo Hills Autonomous District Council (GHADC) on Monday approved a key amendment mandating that only Scheduled Tribe members can contest the polls, effectively ending the participation of non-tribals after over seven decades, officials said.



Chief Minister Conrad Sangma termed the council resolution a ‘historic milestone’.

Ethnic tension

The move follows weeks of unrest and ethnic tensions in parts of Garo Hills.

Two persons died in protests against the participation of non-tribals in the council elections.

The situation was further compounded by political instability within the GHADC, even as pressure mounted on the government to address the long-standing demand for restricting electoral participation to tribal communities.

Following the unrest, the State government had deferred the elections scheduled for April 10 and later decided to extend the tenure of the council by six months to allow the new ex-

ecutive committee to introduce amendments to the rules in line with public demand.

Chief Minister Conrad K. Sangma termed the council resolution a “historic milestone”. “Today is a special session of the district council. The House has passed a resolution that will be remembered in history, making it mandatory for any candidate contesting the council elections to possess a Scheduled Tribe certificate,” he said while addressing a gathering in front of the National People’s Party office in Tura.

The GHADC was constituted under the Sixth Schedule of the Constitution to safeguard the rights and self-governance of tribal communities.

Gehlot accuses Rajasthan govt. of neglecting healthcare sector, leading to collapse of schemes

Mohammed Iqbal
JAIPUR



Former CM Ashok Gehlot

Former Rajasthan Chief Minister Ashok Gehlot on Monday accused the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) government of neglecting the State’s healthcare infrastructure, leading to its collapse and weakening of schemes. Mr. Gehlot said there were delays in treatment and shortage of essential medicines in the hospitals.

‘Extremely alarming’

“It is extremely alarming that the world-class health model established by the [previous] Congress government is being dismantled by the present government,” Mr. Gehlot said in a post on X. He said the key public health schemes had deteriorated, affecting the treatment for thousands of people.

Because of the pending payments under the Rajasthan Government Health Scheme (RGHS), private hospitals were once again preparing to suspend OPD and pharmacy services which would leave government employees and pensioners in a difficult situation, Mr. Gehlot said.

The veteran Congress leader pointed out that an acute shortage of blood at Jaipur’s major hospitals, such as Sawai Man Singh Hospital and Zanana Hospi-

tal, has created a health emergency which could prove life-threatening for patients.

While demanding that the State government lift restrictions on private blood banks, Mr. Gehlot referred to his recent visit to Chaksu near Jaipur, where he met a 108-year-old resident, Goluram Mali. “The villagers voiced dissatisfaction with the BJP government and expressed anger over halted schemes in every sector, including medical and health,” he said.

Mr. Gehlot regretted that Chief Minister Bhajan Lal Sharma starts making personal remarks about him at public events whenever he raised such public issues. “The government should act on public grievances and take immediate corrective steps to improve the worsening situation on the ground,” he said.

CPI(M) accepts 5-seat offer, signs pact with DMK for T.N. election

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

After days of hard bargaining, the CPI(M) on Monday night finally accepted the five seats offered by the DMK for the Tamil Nadu Assembly election. DMK president and Chief Minister M.K. Stalin and CPI(M) State secretary P. Shanmugam signed the agreement at the Anna Arivalayam in Chennai.

“Though not satisfied, we accepted the seats because we do not want to create a favourable condition for the AIADMK-BJP combine,” Mr. Shanmugam said. The CPI(M), which was allotted six seats in the last Assembly election in the same alliance, had begun negotiations with the DMK pitching for the allotment of double digit seats. However, the DMK, citing the entry of more parties in the alliance, refused to concede to the

demand.

Over the past few days, the CPI(M), under pressure from its rank and file and State secretariat, repeatedly went to the negotiation table urging that it be allotted at least the same six seats as last time. However, even a meeting with Mr. Stalin failed to break the ice, with the DMK leader remaining firm in allotting only five seats, a number it had also given the CPI.

VCK resolution

Sources said the Marxist party’s general secretary M.A. Baby had conveyed that in the interest of the INDIA bloc, the party would accept the DMK’s reduced offer.

Meanwhile, the VCK’s high-level committee on Monday passed a resolution seeking “double digit” seats in the upcoming Assembly election and a Rajya Sabha seat to be allotted in 2028.

BJP gets 27 seats for Tamil Nadu poll as Palaniswami announces allocations for AIADMK-led NDA

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), one of the key constituents of the AIADMK-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA) in Tamil Nadu, has been allocated 27 seats for the Assembly election, seven more than its allocation in 2021.

The Pattali Makkal Katchi (PMK) has been allotted 18 seats, five fewer than what it got five years ago. This reduction may be attributed to the perception that the PMK does not enjoy as much strength as it had a few years ago, as Anbumani Ramadoss and his father and PMK founder S. Ramadoss are heading their own factions. Dr. Anbumani’s PMK is a part of the NDA. Headed by T.T.V. Dhinakaran, the Anna Makkal Munnetra Kazhagam has secured 11 seats. Announcing the seat-



United front: Leaders of the NDA at the media briefing held at the AIADMK headquarters in Chennai on Monday. J. JOHAN SATHYADAS

sharing arrangement on Monday at the AIADMK headquarters in Chennai in the presence of Union Minister and BJP’s point-person Piyush Goyal, Mr. Dhinakaran, and Dr. Anbumani, among other leaders, AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami told media persons that talks were in progress with some more parties [such as the Tamil Maanila Congress (Moopanar)] and the details would

be announced soon.

Asked why the BJP was allotted more seats than the PMK, Mr. Palaniswami rebutted the suggestion of any dissonance within the coalition and asserted that this had been finalised in a “cordial way”. Though Tamizhaga Makkal Munnetra Kazhagam founder John Pandian was also present at the media briefing, the AIADMK general secretary did not mention what had been decided for the party.

Headline numbers mask AGP’s steady slide despite 10 years in power in Assam

NEWS ANALYSIS

Abdus Salam
NEW DELHI

While an upstart born in the aftermath of the anti-Citizenship (Amendment) Act protests manages to hold its own against the principal Opposition party, the one synonymous with regionalism in Assam is in terminal decline even after enjoying the perks of power for the past decade.

The Rajior Dal, with party chief Akhil Gogoi its sole MLA in the outgoing Assembly and that too as an Independent contesting from jail, has managed to wrangle 11 seats from the Congress after calling off alliance talks and announcing candidates for 13 seats.

The Asom Gana Parishad (AGP), BJP’s junior

partner in the ruling National Democratic Alliance, has been given 26 seats. The headline number remains intact from the last election in 2021 - the party contested the same number of seats and won nine - but it’s the constituencies AGP has been relegated to that betrays the steady slide and dwindling bargaining chips vis-a-vis its senior partner.

Party president and Minister Atul Bora keeps his Bokakhat constituency and Cabinet colleague Keshab Mahanta has been renominated from Kaliabor. Diptimayee Choudhury, the wife of party elder Phani Bhushan Choudhury, who now represents Barpeta in the Lok Sabha after serving eight consecutive terms as MLA from Bongaigaon, has been renominated. Prithviraj Rabha will defend his



Atul Bora, AGP president and party candidate from Bokakhat constituency, filing his nomination in the presence of Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma in Golaghat on Monday; AGP and BJP supporters during a joint rally on the last day of filing nominations, on the streets of Guwahati. PTI/RITU RAJ KONWAR

Tezpur seat while Prodig Hazarika has been shifted to Sivasagar from Amguri due to delimitation.

These are perhaps the only hurrahs for the regional outfit that was forged in the crucible of the Assam Agitation, swept to power in the mid-1980s, and secured another term in go-

vernment a decade later. Thirteen of the AGP’s candidates this time are from the minority community, the highest proportion among parties barring Badruddin Ajmal’s All India United Democratic Front (AIUDF).

While Mr. Bora explained it away as winnabil-



ity arithmetic and “local dynamics”, the plain truth is that the BJP, which named no Muslim candidate among its 89, has saddled its ally with the bulk of the post-delimitation constituencies with heavy minority concentration.

Local dynamics can scarcely explain the drop-

ping of AGP veteran and party general secretary Ramendra Narayan Kalita, a five-time MLA from Guwahati West constituency, ostensibly on the ground that his constituency is a delimitation casualty. He could have been fielded from the new Guwahati Central seat, which subsumes segments of the abolished seat - instead, the BJP has named Vijay Kumar Gupta.

Tensions had been brewing at the grassroots in several constituencies where local leaders and workers of the AGP fancied the regional party’s chances. The demand was most vociferous in Dergaon and Khumtai in Golaghat district, and Barhampur in Nagaon district; the incumbent legislator in Dergaon is from AGP, and Barhampur - a seat with nostalgic value for having twice

elected former Chief Minister Prafulla Kumar Mahanta - had been ceded to the BJP only in 2021. The AGP gets to contest none of the three this time round.

The diminishing coalition returns for the AGP vis-a-vis BJP with respect to seat distribution comes on the back of similar heartburn in the run-up to the 2021 election.

Back then, the regional party contested 26 seats and won nine, but several constituencies historically associated with it - including Patacharkuchi (now Barjali), Kamalpur, Lakhimpur and Naharkatiya, apart from Barhampur - were wrested by the BJP.

The AGP, then the incumbent party in power, first allied with the BJP in the 2001 Assembly election that heralded an uninterrupted 15-year Congress

rule under current Assam chief Gaurav Gogoi’s father Tarun Gogoi. The party lost power, shedding 39 seats from its 1996 tally of 59, while its junior ally added an equal number of seats to its previous tally of four. By the time the 2016 Assembly election came round, the BJP emerged as the single-largest party with 60 MLAs while AGP won 14 seats.

The big flip

It’s not inconceivable that the now-junior ally could still match the win count from the 2021 poll, a prospect burnished by the entry of two incumbent MLAs from the Barak Valley from the AIUDF and the BJP’s vote-transfer left after two terms in power. But the senior and junior tags have flipped irreversibly, and junior is constantly losing ground.

INBRIEF



Wayanad to get extra ₹10 cr. from Karnataka government

Ahead of the elections to the Kerala Assembly, the Congress government in Karnataka is set to provide an additional grant of ₹10 crore for the rehabilitation of families affected by the landslide in Meppadi of Wayanad district. A provision in this regard has been made in the supplementary estimates of 2025-26 (third and final instalment), tabled in the Karnataka Legislative Assembly on Monday. The supplementary estimates of 2025-26 aggregate to ₹14,767.89 crore.

Kerala High Court stays order disqualifying Yogam leaders

A Division Bench of the Kerala High Court on Monday stayed an order passed by a single judge of the court on March 12 that disqualified general secretary of SNDP Yogam Vellappally Natesan and other office-bearers from their posts in the organisation for failing to file audited accounts for three consecutive years and not having the director identification number issued by the Kerala government. The Bench observed that the appellants had the identification number.

SC restores FIR against IAS officer in 2022 bribery case

The Supreme Court has restored an FIR against IAS officer J. Manjunath in an alleged bribery case, when he was serving as Bengaluru Urban DC in 2022. Now the Lokayukta police can continue the investigation, which was initiated by the erstwhile Anti-Corruption Bureau. The order set aside two separate judgments of the Karnataka HC, which in 2023 quashed the FIR against Mr. Manjunath and Mahesh P.S, a deputy tahsildar working as his Personal Assistant (PA).

Kerala Assembly polls: 1,202 candidates file nominations

Final picture will emerge after scrutiny of nomination papers today and the last date of withdrawal on Thursday; over one lakh complaints have been filed on model code violations

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Election officials here said that 1,202 candidates have filed nomination papers for the April 9 Assembly polls in the State when the deadline for submitting them ended at 3 p.m. on Monday. In all, 2,039 forms have been filed, counting multiple forms submitted by some of the candidates. A final picture on candidates will emerge after the scrutiny of the nomination papers on Tuesday and the March 26 deadline for the withdrawal of candidature. There were 957 candi-



Friendly fight: BJP's Karamana Jayan and LDF's Sudheer Karamana greet each other in the Kerala capital. NIRMAL HARINDRAN

dates in the fray in the 140 constituencies for the 2021 elections in Kerala. As many as 1,39,799 complaints have been filed regarding Model Code of Conduct violations till March 22. Procedures related to the processing of an appli-

cation and adding the name to the electoral roll take up to 10 days. Therefore, only those applications filed on or before March 15 would be treated as eligible for the upcoming Assembly polls, Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) Rathan U. Kelkar said. Speaking at the release of 'Vottarivu,' an election booklet published by the Thiruvananthapuram unit of the Press Information Bureau, Mr. Kelkar sought the cooperation of voters to ensure the highest turnout in Kerala's electoral history. The aim is to cross the 85% voter turnout mark this time, he said.

BJP seal on EC letter sparks row in Kerala

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The presence of a seal of the BJP Kerala unit on a 2019 Election Commission of India (EC) letter on poll-related guidelines, which was distributed to political parties recently, sparked a row in the State on Monday, the final day for submitting nominations for the April 9 Assembly polls. While the ruling CPI(M) alleged that "seals are being casually swapped" and questioned whether "all pretences" have been dropped by the BJP, Chief Electoral Officer (Kerala) (CEO) Rathan U. Kelkar at-



An Election Commission letter bearing the BJP seal that was shared by the CPI(M) on X.

tributed the issue to a "clerical error" and added that corrective measures had been taken. The CPI(M) had shared on its X handle a copy of a March 19, 2019, Election

Commission letter bearing the BJP seal. The letter, to CEOs of all States and Union Territories ahead of the 2019 Lok Sabha polls, dealt with the EC guidelines on the publicity of criminal antecedents by political parties and candidates. Copies of the letter had been issued afresh to political parties by mistake, according to the CEO's office.

Clerical error, says CEO The CEO issued a clarification attributing the episode to a clerical error and asking everyone to avoid spreading the "wrong message." According to him, the

BJP Kerala unit had visited the CEO's office seeking clarification on the EC guidelines. The party seal was on a copy of the EC letter submitted along with the application seeking the clarification. "The old letter was distributed to political parties due to an oversight," Mr. Kelkar said. Once the error was noticed by the CEO's office, all political parties, district election officers, and returning officers were told in writing that the letter was being withdrawn and it should be disregarded, he said.



Locals making donations to express their solidarity with Iran amid the war, in Srinagar's Khumani Chowk on Monday. IMRAN NISSAR

From gold to piggy banks, Kashmir stands by war-ravaged Iran

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

Larger-than-life images of slain Iranian supreme leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei dotted central parks in Srinagar's Shia-majority localities of Zadibal and Hasanabad for the second consecutive day on Monday, even as a donation drive for the medical aid of people affected by the conflict in Iran gathers momentum across the Valley. In a groundswell of support, residents have been contributing cash, gold items, piggy banks, vehicles, and even cattle. Zainab Jan, 9, was one of the youngest donors to arrive early to deposit her piggy bank, which she had been saving for four years. Residents, including those from the lower-income households, donated items such as bikes, copper utensils and livestock. "Traditionally, Kashmiris collect copper utensils for the weddings of their daughters as a means of security. However, we decided to donate them for those daughters who have lost their mothers

and sisters in the ongoing attacks on Iran," said Tahera Jan, 73, at Zadibal. The Iran-U.S.-Israel war has been going on for the past three weeks. According to official Iranian figures, the death toll has crossed 1,500, including children. Against this backdrop, donation drives have been organised across the Valley. "Donations are being collected as medical aid for the people of Iran. The support has been overwhelming. We were moved. Even the poorest are donating whatever they can," said Syed Asifi, one of the organisers at the Khomeini Chowk in Bemina. Iran conveys gratitude Peoples Democratic Party legislator and Shia cleric Muntazir Mehdi, who donated his one month's salary, said, "Humanity must come before everything". Iran, through its official handle on X in India, on Sunday expressed its special gratitude to the people of Kashmir, especially women and children, for their donations and support .

Will meet 20% of daily LPG needs of hotel industry, says Karnataka Minister

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Food and Civil Supplies Minister K.H. Muniyappa on Monday said the Karnataka government would be able to supply 20% of the daily needs of the hotel industry with immediate effect. "On an average, about 45,000 commercial cylinders were being used by hotels in the State. Following a discussion with oil marketing companies to-

day (Monday), it has been decided that about 10,000 commercial cylinders can be supplied to the hotel industry," he said. In a statement to the Legislative Council, the Minister said that in all, the Centre has approved a supply of about 16,105 commercial cylinders daily. "About 4,200 cylinders will be supplied to educational institutions, 1,200 cylinders to public sector undertakings, and 500 to agriculture and allied ac-

tivities. About 200 cylinders will be reserved for emergency uses. As many as 10,000 cylinders will be given to hotels, industrial canteens, restaurants, and dhabas, among others," he added. 'Other option unviable' Amid the ongoing LPG supply disruptions, many small-scale eateries have started procuring domestic LPG cylinders at prices as high as ₹5,000 to keep services running.

Hoteliers said that while some tried switching to alternatives such as induction stoves and firewood-based cooking, these have not proved viable for continuous operations. Induction stoves have not worked as a practical alternative for most small eateries, hoteliers said. "The use is limited to tea, coffee or boiling water. Beyond that, it becomes difficult," Vijay Kumar, owner of an eatery in Vasanth Nagar, said.

Four killed in accident on Bengaluru highway; bus driver held

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Four passengers were killed and several injured in an accident on the Bengaluru-Mysuru highway in Ramanagara district in the early hours of Monday, after a bus crashed into a roadside fence. According to the police, the impact of the crash was severe, leaving the bus badly mangled. Two passengers were killed on the spot, while the other two died of injuries in hospital. The deceased have been identified as Mohammad Farhan (22), and Sulfi Ra-feeze (45), both from Kozhikode in Kerala, and Rash-eed (45), and Sakir (27), from Bengaluru. Two injured passengers – Abdul and Alain from Kannur, Kerala – are currently undergoing treatment in a private hospital. Preliminary investigation revealed that the bus, carrying 43 people, was travelling at a high speed when the driver allegedly dozed off. The vehicle veered to the left and crashed into the roadside fencing, dragging it along for nearly 100 metres. Metal rods from the fence pierced through the left side of the bus, fatally injuring passengers seated there. The driver, Riyaz, initially claimed he swerved to avoid an oncoming vehicle. However, CCTV footage reviewed by the police suggested that he may have fallen asleep at the wheel. The Channapatna Traffic Police have arrested the driver and registered a case of negligent driving.



BENGALURU EAST CITY CORPORATION
Office of the Executive Engineer, Marathahalli Division,
Bellanduru Main Road, Bellanduru, Bengaluru - 560103
No.: BECC/EE/MRH/TN/06/2025-26 Date: 23.03.2026

INVITATION FOR TENDERS (Short Term)
(Only through KPP Portal)
The Executive Engineer, Marathahalli Division, invites **item rate** tenders from the eligible tenderers for the work details in the table given below. The Tenderers shall be registered in Bengaluru East City Corporation / CPWD / KPWD / Railways / MES / any State or Central Govt. Organization.

Sl. No.	Name of the Work
1	Annual maintenance of footpath, desilting of drains and other allied works of arterial and sub-arterial roads in ward no. 41, Munekolala. Amount put to tender (in Lakhs) Exclusive of GST: 59.26, EMD (in Rs.): 59,500/-, Eligibility of Contractor and Category: SC.
2	Desilting of ward roads and engaging tipper and labour in ward no. 41, Munekolala. Amount put to tender (in Lakhs) Exclusive of GST: 101.64, EMD (in Rs.): 1,52,500/-, Eligibility of Contractor and Category: Others.
3	Annual maintenance of footpath, desilting of drains and other allied works of arterial and sub-arterial roads in ward no. 45, Marathahalli. Amount put to tender (in Lakhs) Exclusive of GST: 60.15, EMD (in Rs.): 1,20,500/-, Eligibility of Contractor and Category: Others.
4	Desilting of ward roads and engaging tipper and labour in ward no. 45, Marathahalli. Amount put to tender (in Lakhs) Exclusive of GST: 80.47, EMD (in Rs.): 80,500/-, Eligibility of Contractor and Category: CAT-1.
5	Annual maintenance of footpath, desilting of drains and other allied works of arterial and sub-arterial roads in ward no. 46, Yamaluru. Amount put to tender (in Lakhs) Exclusive of GST: 61.00, EMD (in Rs.): 1,22,000/-, Eligibility of Contractor and Category: Others.
6	Desilting of ward roads and engaging tipper and labour in ward no. 46, Yamaluru. Amount put to tender (in Lakhs) Exclusive of GST: 84.72, EMD (in Rs.): 85,000/-, Eligibility of Contractor and Category: ST.
7	Annual maintenance of footpath, desilting of drains and other allied works of arterial and sub-arterial roads in ward no. 47, Bellanduru. Amount put to tender (in Lakhs) Exclusive of GST: 127.09, EMD (in Rs.): 1,91,000/-, Eligibility of Contractor and Category: Others.
8	Desilting of ward roads and engaging tipper and labour in ward no. 47, Bellanduru. Amount put to tender (in Lakhs) Exclusive of GST: 55.04, EMD (in Rs.): 1,10,500/-, Eligibility of Contractor and Category: CAT-III(A).
9	Annual maintenance of footpath, desilting of drains and other allied works of arterial and sub-arterial roads in ward no. 48, Panathuru. Amount put to tender (in Lakhs) Exclusive of GST: 169.44, EMD (in Rs.): 2,54,500/-, Eligibility of Contractor and Category: Others.
10	Desilting of ward roads and engaging tipper and labour in ward no. 48, Panathuru. Amount put to tender (in Lakhs) Exclusive of GST: 101.62, EMD (in Rs.): 1,52,500/-, Eligibility of Contractor and Category: Others.
11	Annual maintenance of footpath, desilting of drains and other allied works of arterial and sub-arterial roads in ward no. 49, Doddakananahalli. Amount put to tender (in Lakhs) Exclusive of GST: 156.74, EMD (in Rs.): 2,35,500/-, Eligibility of Contractor and Category: Others.
12	Desilting of ward roads and engaging tipper and labour in ward no. 49, Doddakananahalli. Amount put to tender (in Lakhs) Exclusive of GST: 84.70, EMD (in Rs.): 1,69,500/-, Eligibility of Contractor and Category: Others.
13	Filling of potholes in ward no. 41, 45, 46, 47, 48 and 49. Amount put to tender (in Lakhs) Exclusive of GST: 135.58, EMD (in Rs.): 2,03,500/-, Eligibility of Contractor and Category: Others.
14	Annual maintenance of Marathahalli Division of Zone-01 storm water drain in Mahadevapura Constituency. Amount put to tender (in Lakhs) Exclusive of GST: 121.46, EMD (in Rs.): 1,82,500/-, Eligibility of Contractor and Category: Others.

Calendar of events: (1) Tender Documents may be downloaded from Government of Karnataka e-procurement website <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in>. (2) Last date for submission of queries: **30.03.2026** within **11:00 a.m.** (3) Date & time for pre bid meeting: **30.03.2026** at **4:00 p.m.** (4) Last date & time for receipt of tenders: **04.04.2026** upto **4:00 p.m.** (5) Date & time for opening of Technical bid: **06.04.2026** at **4:00 p.m.** (6) Date & time for opening of Financial bid: **07.04.2026** at **4:00 p.m.** Further details may be obtained from the above office during office hours or website <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in>
Sd/- Executive Engineer, Marathahalli Division, BECC



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TIRUMALA TIRUPATI DEVASTHANAMS - TIRUPATI
EXECUTIVE ENGINEER - VII e-AUCTION NOTICE

TTD is disposing scrap materials (Iron scrap, Teak wood, plastic, Stainless Steel, Assorted Coir beds and pillows etc., available in the DPW Stores Civil, TTD, Tirupathi through e-Auction (Online) to be held on 04-04-2026, 2.00 PM to 5.00 PM on e- KONGULU Portal, Govt. of A.P. The registered bidders in "Kongulu" are eligible to participate in the Auction. Further details please log on to <https://kongulu.ap.gov.in> or www.tirumala.org or contract No.7702510006/9701391777
TTD-40021/10/2025-PRO SEC(Adv.No.443) Date:23-03-2026 **EXECUTIVE OFFICER**

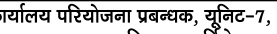


GOVERNMENT OF TELANGANA
ROADS & BUILDINGS DEPARTMENT

***e* Procurement Notice 1.** Online tenders are invited under the e-procurement platform in Peddapalli, Khannam, Nizamabad, Districts. For 3 Bridge works & 8 Road works under Plan & Non Plan for an amount of Rs.350.52 crores vide CE(R&B), SR, e-NIT No. 11/E-C(SR&RNS)/SE/D&P/HIEE-WIDEE/IAEE/2026 dt: 20. 03.2026.

S.No.	District	List of works No. of works	Scheme	Amount Crores
1	Peddapalli	2	PLAN	228
2	Nizamabad	2	Non-Plan	0.82
3	Khannam	3	PLAN	116
4	Medak	3	Non-Plan	2
5	Nizamabad	3	STSDP	350.52
Total Amount				350.52

2. Tenderers can download the tender schedule and further details can be seen from the e-marketplace i.e., Procurement marketplace at <https://tender.telangana.gov.in/>. The last date of receipt of tenders is 06.04.2026 at 3. Further, Corrigendum to the CTN issued vide NIT No. 1606-S/DCE/IE/IE/R/DEE/IAEE/V/2025-26, dated 06.03.2026 vide reference 2nd cited, The Modified last date for receipt of tenders for 8 Nos. of works in Suryapet District, 2 Nos in Medchal Malkajgiri District is 31.03.2026 up to 4.00 PM.
DPR R.O.No.17439-32/CMAD/VI/10/2025-26 Dt: 23.03.2026 Sd/- For Engineer-in-Chief (R&B) State Roads & CRN, MD-TGDCD



कार्यालय परियोजना प्रबंधक, सुनिट-7,
कन्नड़कुशन एण्ड डिजाइन सर्विसेज
उपप्रो जल निगम (नगरीय)
(उपप्रो सरकार का उपक्रम)
का.नं.ता: ए-212, ब्लाक-ए, वेदव्यासपुरी,
मेरठ-250005
E-mail id : cds.unit7@gmail.com

ई-निविदा सूचना
निविदा सूचना सं. 1085/E-Tender/87
दिनांक : 23.03.2026
ई-निविदा सूचना
उत्तर प्रदेश जल निगम, की ओर से अयोध्याखर्वा द्वारा CONSTRUCTION OF FOUNDATION AND FLOOR (PLATFORM) OF SOLAR ENERGY ASSISTED EXTRACTION SYSTEM FOR HIGH VALUE AROMATIC/MEDICINAL PRODUCTS AT SVBP AGRICULTURE UNIVERSITY MEERUT (U.P.) के निर्माण अनुमानित लागत रु. 7.66 लाख (की.एस.टी.: रहित एवं लेबर सेस सहित) हेतु सी.एण्ड डी.एस. में यथोचित श्रेणी में भवन कार्य हेतु पंजीकृत ठेकेदारों से दिनांक 24.04.2026 के अपरान्त 15.00 बजे तक ई-निविदाएं आमंत्रित की जाती हैं। उक्त कार्य हेतु ई-निविदा प्रपत्र दिनांक 24.03.2026 से दिनांक 24.04.2026 के मध्य उत्तर प्रदेश सरकार की e-procurement वेबसाइट <https://etender.up.nic.in> से डाउनलोड किये जा सकते हैं तथा ई-निविदा दिनांक 24.04.2026 को अपरान्त 16.30 बजे सी.एण्ड डी.एस. सुनिट-07, ज. प्र. जल निगम, मेरठ में निविदा खोली जायेगी ई-निविदा प्रपत्र का मूल्य रु. 1000 + GST (18%) अतिरिक्त देय होगा। ई-निविदा से सम्बन्धित विस्तृत विवरण विभाग की वेबसाइट www.cdsupjn.org एवं प्रोक्वोरमेंट पोर्टल <https://etender.up.nic.in> पर उपलब्ध है। समस्त शुद्धि पत्र (Corrigendum) <https://etender.up.nic.in> पर ही अपलोड किये जायेंगे, इनका प्रयुक्त से कोई प्रकाशन नहीं किया जायेगा। निविदादाताओं को सलाह दी जाती है कि वे उक्त वेबसाइट का समय-समय पर अवलोकन करते रहें।

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE
DEATH
S. THYAGARAJAN (85), RETIRED ASSOCIATE EDITOR (Sports), THE HINDU, Chennai passed away on 23- March 2026, Address 2, Krishna Avenue, C V Raman Nagar, Alwarpet, Chennai-600018. Contact: 9884261077

SAD DEMISE


M.S.Soundararajan
M.Com., B.L., MBA., CAIIB
DOB: 28-4-1957 DOD: 14-3-2026
Advocate (Business & Corporate Laws)
Ex Officer Canara Bank - Circle Office
Subhasweekaram on 26/3/2026
(Thursday 11 to 1 pm)
Commemoration on 29/3/2026 (Sunday)
Deeply mourned by
Wife: Ultra Soundararajan
Daughter :
Adv. Sona Priyadarshini Soundararajan
MOB : 94431 49068
82204 68318.

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CHANGE OF NAME

PERSONAL

CHANGE OF NAME

I, ASHISH Dhalwal, s/o Virender Singh, r/o RZ-133, B-Block, Roshan Vihar, Najafgarh, Delhi – 110043, have changed my name to Ashish Chaudhary. Henceforth, I shall be known as Ashish Chaudhary for all purposes.

I, SOURABH Dhalwal, s/o Virender Singh, r/o RZ-133, B-Block, Roshan Vihar, Najafgarh, Delhi – 110043, have changed my name to Sourabh Chaudhary. Henceforth, I shall be known as Sourabh Chaudhary for all purposes.

LEGAL NOTICE

IN THE COURT OF THE JMFC (CITY), CUTTACK
I.C.C. Case No. 198/2020

Sri Jasobanta Das, Authorized Signatory of M/s. Emerald Capital Services, At-Plot No.32A, Bima Vihar, Sector-6, P.S.- Markat Nagar, CDA, Dist-Cuttack (Odisha), Pin-753014.....Complainant.

-Versus-

1. M/s. Singla Sons LLP, A 17A SFS HIG Flat, Mayur Vihar, Phase-3, P.S.-Ashok Nagar, Delhi-6
2. Mr. Brijesh Singla, Director of M/s. Singla Sons LLP, A 17A SFS HIG Flat, Mayur Vihar, Phase-3, Ashok Nagar, Delhi-6
3. Prateek Gupta Partner of Singla Sons LLP, A 17A SFS HIG Flat, Mayur Vihar, Phase-3, P.S.- Ashok Nagar, Delhi-6.....Accused Persons.

Order Dated : 11.03.2026:
This case record is posted today. The Ld. Counsel for complainant prayed to pass necessary order U/s 82 of CrPC for proclamation on dtd.18.11.2025. On perusal, it is found that, this is a case U/s 138 of N.I. Act filed on dtd.20.08.2020. The NBW was not executed since 21.04.2022. On 17.10.2025 a letter was issued to DCP, Cuttack for its early execution but the same was not executed. Learned counsel for complainant moves to take up the said petition of dtd. 27.02.2026. Heard and perused the petition. This court thinks it proper to issue proclamation U/s 82 of CrPC i.e. the proclamation; be published in a daily newspaper circulating in the place in which such person ordinarily resides before attachment of any property U/s. 83 of CrPC at the cost of complainant and a copy of the newspaper be submitted to this court. Accordingly, the above said petition is allowed. Put up on 13.04.2026 for further order.

Sd/- Illegible
11.3.2026
JMFC(C), Cuttack

UJVN LIMITED

H.O.: "UJJWAL", Maharani Bagh, G.M.S. Road, Dehradun-248006
Telephones: 0135-2763808, Fax: 0135-2763508
CIN No. U40101UR2001SGC025866 Website: www.ujvnl.com

Letter No: 233 Date Extension Notice-03 Date: 23/03/2026

Due to unavoidable circumstances, due dates in respect of online Bid Identification Nos.: (i)T-04/EE(Solar)/2025-26 (ii)T-05/EE (Solar)/2025-26

(iii) T-06/EE(Solar)/2025-26 & (iv)T-07/EE(Solar)/2025-26 are as follows:
Last Date/Time of Receipt of bid on the portal: 28-03-2026 upto 16:00 Hrs.
Last Date/Time of submission of bid in Office: 30-03-2026 upto 12:00 Hrs.
Date of opening of the bid on website : 30-03-2026 from 13:00 Hrs.

All other details and terms & condition shall remain same. Detail of subsequent addendum/corrigendum/cancelation etc. may be obtained from the website.

Further details can be seen from the e-procurement portal <http://uktenders.gov.in>.

Executive Engineer (Solar)

"AVOID WASTEFUL USE OF ELECTRICITY"

TRIPURA RENEWABLE ENERGY DEVELOPMENT AGENCY
(Department of Power, Government of Tripura)

PNle-T No.F.6(575)/TREDA/NCES/2025-26/2706 Date 20/03/2026

NOTICE INVITING e-TENDER

On behalf of Tripura Renewable Energy Development Agency (TREDA), Joint Director, TREDA invites e-tender for "Rate Contract for Pre-Dispatch Inspection (PDI) of components of Renewable Energy Systems on PAN Indis basis" vide DNle-T No.F.6(575)/TREDA/NCES/2025-26/2705, dated 20/03/2026.

The tender papers may be downloaded from e-procurement portal <https://tripuratenders.gov.in> and the deadline for submission of online e-bid is 16/04/2026 up to 3:00 PM.

(D S DAS)
Joint Director

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-Tender Notice No. : JHS-N-W-23-26 Date : 20.03.2026

E-Tendering Tender Notice

Sr. Divisional Signal & Telecommunication Engineer/Jhansi, DRM's office, Jhansi for and on behalf of President of India invite open Tender through on Line (E-Tendering) for the following works.

E-Tender No. : JHS-N-W-23-26 Approx Cost : Rs. 8017403.84/-

Description of work : Shifting of existing Telephone Exchange and OFC equipment to new temporary construction office at PF-01 and shifting of temporary Telephone Exchange and OFC equipment to new permanent building regarding Station redevelopment work at Gwalior station.

Earnest Money : Rs. 160400/- Cost of Tender Form : Nil.

Opening of tender : 13.04.2026 Time : 15:00

Completion period from issue of letter of acceptance : 09 Months

* Tender on line can be submitted upto 15:00 hrs on 13.04.2026 * For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways website www.reps.gov.in (NORTH CENTRAL RLY/JHANSI DIVISION-S AND T) 644/26 (AS)

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Office of the Executive Engineer, Special Division,
BWCC Building, No.161, 2nd Floor, 19th Main, 2nd Block,
Near Old Navarang Bus Stop, Rajajinagara, Bengaluru - 560010.

No: BWCC/EE/SPL/TEND/05/2025-26 Date: 23-03-2026

INVITATION FOR TENDER (IFT)
(Two Cover System) (Through GOK KPP Portal only)

The Executive Engineer, Special Division, BWCC, Bengaluru invites Tenders from the registered Service Provider / Contractors of GBA - BWCC or equivalent registration with CPWD / KPWD / Railways / MES or any State Government Organizations for the Services detailed below.

Sl. No.	Name of the Work
1	Establishing Control Room in Malleshwaram Zone-2 (Supplying Man Power and Other Equipments) for 12 Months. Amount Put to Tender (Excluding GST) (Rs. in Lakhs): 112.85, EMD Amount (in Rs.): 2,00,000/-

Calendar of Events: 1) Tender documents may be downloaded from the GOK Karnataka Public Procurement Portal Website: <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in> from 24-03-2026, 17.30 Hours onwards. 2) Last Date for Receipt of Queries: 30-03-2026 upto 16.00 Hours. 3) Pre Bid Meeting will be held on 30-03-2026 at 16.00 Hours in the Office of the Executive Engineer (Special Division), Malleshwaram Zone-2. 4) Last Date and Time for Uploading the Tender Documents: 04-04-2026 upto 16.00 Hours. 5) Date of Opening of Technical Bid: 06-04-2026 at 16.30 Hours. 6) Date of Opening of Financial Bid: Will be intimated to the Technically Qualified Bidders. Further details can be had from the above office.
Sd/- Executive Engineer
Special Division, Malleshwaram Zone, BWCC.





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By
YOGI ADITYANATH
Chief Minister, Uttar Pradesh

In the august presence of

Keshav Prasad Maurya
Deputy Chief Minister, Uttar Pradesh

Suresh Kumar Khanna
Minister, Finance & Parliamentary Affairs, Uttar Pradesh

Nand Gopal Gupta 'Nandi'
Minister, Industrial Development, Export Promotion, NRI & Investment Promotion, Uttar Pradesh

Jaswant Singh Saini
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NOTIFICATION

Navodaya Vidyalaya Samiti, an autonomous organization under the Ministry of Education (Department of School Education & Literacy) invites applications through proper channel from eligible candidates for filling up one (01) post of Deputy Commissioner (Finance) in Pay Level- 12 of 7th CPC on deputation for its Headquarters at NOIDA initially for a period of three years as per standard terms and conditions of deputation prescribed by Govt. of India.

The detailed information regarding qualification, experience, etc. and prescribed proforma for application is available under 'Recruitment section' on the website www.navodaya.gov.in. The last date for submission of application is 30.04.2026.

Issued by Navodaya Vidyalaya Samiti

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Autonomous organization under
Ministry of Education,
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NOTIFICATION

The notification published in the Employment News edition 31.05.2025 to 06.06.2025 for filling up a post of Deputy Commissioner (Finance) on deputation basis in Navodaya Vidyalaya Samiti is hereby **withdrawn** due to administrative reasons.

Issued by Navodaya Vidyalaya Samiti



M ND-NDE



Battle of Bengal

The TMC is fighting off anti-incumbency sentiment

The West Bengal Assembly election, to be held in two phases on April 23 and 29, is shaping up as a two-party race between the incumbent All India Trinamool Congress (TMC) and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP). The Left and the Congress have been pushed to the margins in the intense combat. The Bharatiya Gorkha Prajatantrik Morcha (BGPM) is contesting the three Darjeeling hill seats as an ally of the TMC. The TMC, which has been in power for three terms, has replaced 74 sitting Members of the Legislative Assembly to deflect anti-incumbency and bring in fresh faces to the field. In 2021, the TMC won 215 seats with a 48.02% vote share while the BJP secured 77 seats with 38%, a sharp rise from when it bagged just three seats and a 10.2% vote share in 2016. Chief Minister and TMC leader Mamata Banerjee is facing off against Leader of the Opposition Suwendu Adhikari, from the BJP, in Bhabanipur, where she is the sitting MLA. In 2021, she had lost to Mr. Adhikari in Nandigram by a margin of 1,956 votes, even while the TMC won yet another term. The run-up to the election in 2026 has been marred by controversies around the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of the voter list. West Bengal's final electoral roll, which was published on February 28, saw the electorate shrink from 7.66 crore to 7.04 crore, with over 62 lakh names deleted. A further 60 lakh names remain under adjudication even as campaigning is underway, creating unprecedented uncertainty.

The standoff over SIR has overshadowed other debates. Having been in power for three terms, there is much that the TMC should be held accountable for, but SIR turned out to be a gift for Ms. Banerjee, which she has used to amplify her charges against the BJP that it is a party hostile to West Bengal and its voters. The BJP began 2026 with a reasonable case in its favour – the rape and murder of a trainee doctor in Kolkata, in 2024, had shaken public confidence in the Mamata government. But the party's limitations – and even refusal – to negotiate the cultural and linguistic diversity of India are markedly visible in the State, and it is placing its hopes on the trimmed voter list and the manoeuvrability of the electoral process. Its State unit is a house divided, while the TMC appears to have consolidated itself further, with Ms. Banerjee and her nephew Abhishek firmly in command. The BJP's upward trajectory may have hit the ceiling. The Congress is contesting without any alliances. The Left is not a power contender, but its vote share in select seats could influence margins in a tight race. In a long campaign period, there may be some surprises in store in West Bengal, as the BJP and the TMC both fight a battle for survival.

Grim future

India's economic fundamentals need a realistic reassessment

The economy has recently been yielding some discomfiting data, even before the war in West Asia began. The most recent of these was the February 2026 data on the Index of Eight Core Industries. This release showed that growth in the overall Index had dropped to a three-month low in February, half the rate of what it saw in January. This was not a case of a high base effect, either, with growth in February 2025 having been just 3.4%. The sector-wise data reveal further issues. The domestic crude oil industry has been contracting for six consecutive months. In fact, the sector has contracted in 20 out of the last 24 months. The natural gas sector, too, has contracted for the last 20 consecutive months. As context, from about the middle of last year, it had been increasingly clear that there would be some sort of escalation between the U.S. and Iran, even if the exact nature of the war now could not have been predicted then. It is no secret that India is highly dependent on energy imports, especially from the region that would have faced the brunt of any such escalation. As a matter of fact, a large part of the contraction in domestic production was likely because imports were coming cheap. Yet, as tensions increased, it might have been more prudent to have increased domestic oil and gas production over the last eight months so as to at least build reserves, if not to also temporarily reduce import dependence. Permanently reducing such dependence will take time, but a temporary domestic production push – as is belatedly underway – might have considerably alleviated the current supply crunch. Hindsight is 20-20, but that does not excuse a lack of foresight or an inability to learn. The Pradhan Mantri Ujjwala Yojana of 2016 should have triggered a concerted policy to secure LPG supplies and reserves.

This poor core sector performance comes on top of the new series of GDP data showing that the Indian economy is actually smaller than previously thought. Further, between 2022-23 and 2025-26, the contributions to GDP of key engines such as private consumption, capital formation, exports and imports have all fallen. The share of 'change in stocks' has nearly doubled, however, meaning that there is production but not enough sales. Soon, that production too will reduce to fall in line with the subdued demand. All of this leads into the impact of the current crisis. With commercial fuel sources curtailed, oil prices at more than \$100 a barrel, and global economic uncertainty at a high, economists and rating agencies are already downgrading India's growth outlook to about 6.5%. Perhaps, India's much-vaunted macroeconomic fundamentals and resilience need a more realistic assessment.

Two weeks ago, in the run-up to World Tuberculosis (TB) Day (which falls on March 24), the World Health Organization (WHO) formally recommended the use of new near point-of-care (NPOC) molecular tests for diagnosing TB. WHO also endorsed the use of tongue swab samples for TB testing and sputum pooling strategies to potentially improve testing efficiencies at scale. These are the latest developments in what has been an unusually remarkable decade for the TB diagnostic landscape, a decade when new technologies have not only emerged but have also been tested, swiftly recommended and utilised to advance global efforts to eliminate TB.

Probably the best example is the rapidly expanding use of portable chest X-ray (CXR), in tandem with artificial intelligence (AI) solutions for TB screening. In India, the National Tuberculosis Elimination Programme (NTEP) has made available hundreds of portable CXR machines that are being utilised for the Pradhan Mantri TB Mukta Bharat Abhiyaan, in an effort to take active TB screening into the community.

Until recently, X-ray access was limited to hospital settings and dependent on the availability of technicians and radiologists to record the X-ray and interpret the findings. Today, active case-finding efforts are in full swing through mobile vans equipped with portable CXR with AI, making it more convenient. While this takes diagnostic services into the community, we must ensure on-the-spot collection of sputum samples for those with any CXR findings to significantly reduce attrition in the diagnostic cascade. Further, those with CXR lesions other than TB (for example, lung cancer) must get the referral and treatment services they need. Systematic microplanning will also help to refine these screening efforts to focus on those who are most vulnerable, particularly in urban and tribal settings.

The use of AI also presents a credible option for opportunistic screening. Tens of thousands of X-rays are performed daily across India in public and private clinics and hospitals for various reasons. Installing AI algorithms in digital X-ray machines that can swiftly identify suspicious lesions, whether for TB or other respiratory disorders, can reduce delays in diagnosis. Building health system capacity, particularly at the service delivery level, to use AI effectively is an important first step.

The diagnostic landscape is shifting

India has long relied on sputum smear microscopy as the primary test for diagnosing TB, despite its low sensitivity and inability to identify drug-resistance. In 2016, India began scaling up molecular testing – starting with the Cartridge-based Nucleic Acid Amplification Test



Dr. Soumya Swaminathan

is Chairperson of the M.S. Swaminathan Research Foundation and National Science Chair, Anusandhan National Research Foundation (ANRF)

Strengthening the tuberculosis testing infrastructure with an expanded diagnostic toolbox will improve outcomes and support TB elimination efforts

(CBNAAT) and later adopting the indigenous Truenat in 2020. Today, many more Indian products are available, and decentralised access to molecular testing is central to the TB programme.

However, access to up-front molecular testing remains uneven. To achieve 100% testing through NAAT prior to treatment initiation, we must also strengthen sputum collection and transportation mechanisms, especially for the elderly, people with disabilities, and those who live in hard-to-reach areas. To complete the diagnostic cascade swiftly, we must reduce delays in first-line and second-line drug resistance testing and work with the general health system to leverage diagnostic human resource capacity. Minimising test turnaround time will ensure that people with drug-resistant TB are started on the correct treatment regimen at the earliest.

With WHO's endorsement of near point-of-care Nucleic Acid Amplification Tests (nPOC-NAAT), there are now more options for molecular testing at the primary-care level that are not heavily dependent on infrastructure. The use of non-sputum samples, such as tongue swabs, are especially useful for those who find it difficult to produce a good sputum sample, including children.

It is important to acknowledge that none of these tools is a complete solution in itself. What this growing collection of new tests offers is a comprehensive toolbox for TB diagnosis. Diagnostic network optimisation can help identify which tools to best use, individually and in combination, and where they should be located, to establish a diagnostic cascade that is accessible, affordable and person-centered. India must field-test these tools through robust implementation research that matches the pace of innovation, so that solutions can be tested in specific settings and decisions taken for scale-up.

Indian innovators have made a significant contribution, bringing to the market screening and diagnostic tools for global use, and will continue to play an important role in taking them to scale across the country. Over the years, we must examine the evidence to evolve clear diagnostic algorithms that are operationally feasible, involving the use of both AI-enabled CXR and molecular tests for diagnosing TB and identifying any antibiotic resistance.

Research and innovation priorities

Simultaneously, we must streamline innovation assessment and procurement pathways so that all evidence is rigorously reviewed by the Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR), comprehensive health technology assessments address clinical, social, economic, and ethical concerns, and only recommended tools are

procured and distributed in both public and private sectors. Several areas still require research and innovation.

First, as India is scaling up testing for TB infection and access to TB preventive therapy (TPT), we need more cost-effective and easy-to-use biomarkers that can identify and predict those at high risk for disease progression. Studies have shown that 'test and treat' approaches are more likely to convince people with TB infection to start on TPT, if they are at higher risk for disease, particularly in the private sector.

Second, the National TB Survey shows that asymptomatic TB is a serious issue, making

symptom-based screening alone insufficient. Increased access to chest X-ray is a step in the right direction but we also need faster, less invasive diagnostic tools that use saliva and other non-sputum samples. More feasibility studies are required to understand utility and performance in real-world settings, particularly among individuals with low

bacterial load. Third, diagnosing TB in children remains challenging. Children cannot produce sputum as they often have low bacillary levels. Testing using stool samples has been tried in some countries and we need more implementation research in this area. We need far greater investment – and urgency – in finding the right new tools for diagnosing TB in children.

Finally, diagnosing extra-pulmonary TB (EP-TB) – which is almost a quarter of India's TB burden – remains difficult, often inaccessible and very expensive. Misdiagnosis as well as delayed diagnosis of EP-TB contributes to both catastrophic costs for families and poor outcomes for individuals. There are some pilots being done globally using AI-enabled portable ultrasound devices alongside molecular testing using new tools; we need India-specific evidence on this, including on cost-effectiveness.

Investing in strengthening the diagnostic landscape can be the greatest return on investment for the public health system. The sooner a person with TB is diagnosed, ideally before they are very ill, the more likely they are to recover fully, with fewer long-term post-treatment morbidities. Early diagnosis can not only improve treatment outcomes and long-term lung health but also dramatically reduce transmission within communities. A careful but swift and streamlined public sector expansion of diagnostics can also significantly reduce out-of-pocket expenditure for families affected by TB. An evidence-based, strong and expanded diagnostic toolbox can be a powerful lever to accelerate pathways to TB elimination in India.



A decade of building India's TB Champion movement

In early 2017, at a workshop in New Delhi, Cedric Fernandes, a tuberculosis (TB) survivor and advocate from Maharashtra, said to a room full of other TB survivors, "It has been very lonely having this disease. I am fed up with the loneliness and I hope all of you are too." Addressing the organising team at the workshop, he gently admonished us: "I am so glad that someone is finally bringing us together ... but what took so long?"

India diagnoses and treats over 25 lakh people with TB every year, which means that there are hundreds of thousands of individuals such as Cedric, who are coming to terms with the disease and fighting to overcome it. Their path, from diagnosis to cure, is often fraught with challenges in an ecosystem where stigma and social exclusion continue to thrive within communities. TB remains one of the most stigmatised illnesses in both urban and rural India; stigma and discrimination uniquely impact women, men, transgender communities, children and adolescents, the elderly and other socially vulnerable groups.

Challenging the belief

One of the early criticisms of the global TB response was that it remained stubbornly biomedical, focusing solely on clinical interventions whilst excluding communities and devaluing lived experience. Back in 2016, when we first began to imagine and build our wish list for how TB-affected communities – people with TB, TB survivors and their families – could play a greater role, there were many sceptics. Most of all, we were told that TB survivors, unlike people living with HIV, would want to move on with their lives once they had completed treatment, and would not be interested in becoming peer supporters or advocates. Ten years later, the evolution of the TB Champion movement in India has firmly dispelled this notion. TB Champions are survivors who are passionate, motivated and committed individuals, firm in their conviction



Dr. Nalini Krishnan

is Co-Founder and Executive Secretary of the Resource Group for Education and Advocacy for Community Health (REACH), a non-profit organisation working on tuberculosis (TB) for 27 years and a pioneer of the TB Survivor to Champion model



Anupama Srinivasan

is Deputy Director, Resource Group for Education and Advocacy for Community Health (REACH)

Survivors become 'TB Champions', supporting treatment, awareness and community engagement

that they have an important role to play in India's response to TB.

India's National TB Elimination Programme (NTEP) provides access to high-quality free diagnostics and treatment. Over the last few years, diagnosis and case-finding have accelerated, and treatment outcomes have steadily improved, which means that more people are being cured and mortality has reduced, with fewer people dying of TB. Newer strategies – Artificial Intelligence-enabled screening, active case-finding within communities, shorter and less toxic treatment regimens, expanded nutrition support, differentiated care approaches – have been adopted. But even the most robust health system cannot achieve elimination of any disease on its own, without active community participation. This is where TB Champions are uniquely poised to draw on their own personal experiences of TB to be powerful communicators and advocates for changes.

'Empower, support, educate'

In the early years of working with TB survivors, our focus was on developing the 'Survivor to Champion' training curriculum, which has since been formally adopted by the NTEP.

The involvement of TB Champions has reaffirmed a conviction that we have held from our inception – that a person with TB needs emotional support and motivation to get them through the treatment period, as much as they need high-quality clinical care. TB Champion-led peer counselling, through both one-to-one communication and support groups, has helped to improve treatment literacy and empowered people with TB with the knowledge they need. We have found a greater level of confidence and comfort among people with TB who have been supported by TB Champions and a significant reduction in self-stigmatisation.

Even today, myths and misconceptions about

TB persist. TB Champions have played a critical role in dispelling these and in improving knowledge of TB, the symptoms of the disease and where to seek care. They literally reach the last mile through regular community meetings, where they talk about the disease, share their own stories and reassure people that TB is a treatable and curable disease. This has been a powerful anti-stigma strategy, enabling people to come forward to seek diagnosis and treatment.

Building networks, looking ahead

In addition, over the last decade, TB Champions in several States have come together to form survivor-led networks. These collective entities are naturally designed to be a powerful bridge between those seeking care and those providing services, especially among social vulnerable groups. Importantly, networks have become a source of strength for TB survivors, many of whom continue to experience the physical, social and

economic toll of the disease even after being cured. However, the long-term future and sustainability of networks remains uncertain, given that they are dependent on external resources for funding. The next challenge is to test and build self-sustaining socio-economic models for survivor-led networks.

Over the last 10 years, we have been humbled by the trust that thousands of TB Champions from across the country have placed in us. They have travelled long distances to attend our workshops, sharing their TB journeys and stories, their pain and successes. They have become empowered local leaders, unafraid to use the TB Champion moniker to refer to themselves. They remain staunchly committed to working with their communities – supporting people with TB and their families, talking about stigma, meeting their panchayat leaders – and doing all of this for one simple, powerful reason – 'so that no one else should suffer like I did'.



LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Erratic policy

The dramatic post by U.S. President Donald Trump, on a 'five-day ceasefire of sorts', must have stunned Benjamin Netanyahu's Israel. The 'second coming' of Mr. Trump has been marked less by strategic doctrine and more by disruptive impulse. Alliances

once seen as bedrock as NATO, have been treated as transactional, their value weighed against immediate domestic optics rather than long-term geopolitical balance. Trade agreements and multilateral pacts have been entered and exited with disconcerting ease, reinforcing a perception of

the U.S. as an uncertain partner. In conflict theatres, this inconsistency has been stark. Support extended to Ukraine appeared forceful yet episodic, leaving allies unsure of endurance. Europe, once a strategic anchor, has often been addressed with impatience rather than partnership.

Even Israel, a beneficiary of unequivocal backing, has found that patronage can pivot abruptly.
R. Narayanan,
Navi Mumbai

PNG transition issue

I wish to draw the attention of government officials to a troubling issue being faced

by many consumers registered for piped natural gas (PNG) connections with GAIL (India) Limited. Under the recent government mandate (LPG Amendment Order 2026), households with functional PNG connections must surrender their domestic LPG cylinders. However, GAIL

officials and distributors are reportedly asking consumers to surrender their LPG connections before the PNG line has been installed or activated.
Parthasarathy P.,
New Delhi

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

From disease-specific to person-centred care

By using TB as an entry point, integrated healthcare delivery can optimise and improve public health efficiency



Anupama Srinivasan
Deputy Director of REACH



Dr. Ramya Anantha Krishnan
Director of REACH

Tuberculosis (TB) rarely presents as a standalone disease in an individual. Many people with TB have other comorbidities or disease conditions that they must simultaneously cope with, while being on treatment for TB. Therefore, treating TB alone is not enough. Adopting integrated care approaches by transitioning from disease-specific to person-centred care can accelerate India's efforts to achieve both universal health coverage and TB elimination. Simply put, we must treat the person and not the disease.

Take the example of Divya (name changed), a 48-year-old woman who was diagnosed with TB in 2023. She had been living with diabetes and hypertension for several years and it is highly likely that her diabetes played a role in her contracting TB. Crucially, she had poor glycemic control with a HbA1c over 10, which had a direct impact on her treatment for TB.

Infectious diseases like TB; non-communicable diseases such as diabetes and chronic respiratory diseases; malnutrition; and social and economic vulnerabilities inevitably

intersect in individuals and families, adversely impacting outcomes and the overall quality of life. Recognising the interconnected nature of these multiple vulnerabilities is the first step towards delivering integrated care.

Treating TB and diabetes

As in the case of Divya, an important opportunity for integration is between TB and diabetes, given India's growing diabetes burden. Over 15 years ago, the National TB Elimination Programme (NTEP) identified diabetes as a key comorbidity for TB, and rolled out formal bidirectional screening guidelines for TB-diabetes. Every person with TB must be screened for diabetes and people with diabetes must ideally be screened for TB once a year. Studies have shown that people with diabetes are more likely to develop active TB disease than those without; equally, people with TB who also have diabetes are more likely to have poor TB treatment outcomes.

In Chennai, in a cohort of over 9,000 people with TB for three years, the authors found that over



TB patients seen inside the Govind Ballabh Pant Hospital on March 24, 2025. ANI

one-third (34%) had diabetes, and of this group, 41% had poor glycemic control which is the biggest challenge. Monitoring the blood sugar levels of a person with TB and diabetes throughout the TB treatment period is therefore essential, as is expanding clinical management and the counselling that is provided from TB-specific guidance to also focus on overall lifestyle, physical activity, diet and nutrition etc.

Integrating respiratory care

Another important opportunity for integration is at the intersection of TB and Chronic Respiratory Diseases (CRD) such as asthma or Chronic Obstructive Pulmonary Disease (COPD), at the screening stage itself. Only a fraction of people with respiratory symptoms are eventually diagnosed with TB – the rest are likely to have viral flu, bronchitis, asthma etc. In REACH's ongoing TB-CRD integrated care

pilot in two districts each of Bihar and Tamil Nadu, nearly 3,000 people with COPD and asthma were identified and linked to care, among the 26,000 people who were screened for TB but found TB-negative. In addition, integrated care can also change the course of post-treatment follow-up, given that many people who complete TB treatment continue to have respiratory impairments.

Other areas of intersection include undernutrition and risk factors such as smoking and alcohol use. This multi-disease approach is already envisaged in the framework of the Ayushman Arogya Mandirs for delivering comprehensive care at the community and primary care levels.

Delivering integrated care at scale can have its share of challenges. At the health system level, it is a likely stressor on already strained human resources, with the brunt of the workload falling on community health workers. In addition, many of India's large health programmes are vertical and not always de-

signed to talk to each other, in terms of both human resources and data; this will require both creative and pragmatic solutions.

Integrated care delivery will require adequate and additional human resources, a careful readjustment of the health worker to care recipient ratio and investment in periodic training.



Holistic wellness

Given that the NTEP is among India's more robust, well-structured public health programmes, using TB as an entry point to identify and address closely associated morbidities such as diabetes, CRDs, undernutrition etc. will help optimise healthcare delivery and improve public health efficiency. More importantly, it could reduce delays in diagnosis, minimise the need for visits to several health facilities, and help overcome barriers to accessing a continuum of care. With empathetic person-centred design, integrated healthcare delivery can be a win-win for health systems, individuals and families affected by TB.

The need to integrate nutrition in TB care

For most patients with TB who are severely underweight, nutritional support is an essential and not optional part of treatment



Dr. Madhavi Bhargava

is a public health specialist and teaches at Yenepoya Medical College, Mangalore. Led the RATIONS trial in India



Dr. Anurag Bhargava

is a physician-epidemiologist and teaches at Kasturba Medical College, Mangalore. Led the RATIONS trial in India

In 2026, India still has the highest number of new cases of Tuberculosis (TB) globally and a decreasing but still unacceptable number of about three lakh deaths due to TB. Almost 10% of successfully treated patients have recurrence within two years. An answer to all these challenges may partly lie in addressing a leading cause and consequence of TB in India, which is undernutrition, closely related to poverty, food insecurity and a predominantly cereal-based diet with deficient protein intake.

On the occasion of World TB Day, evidence from the Reducing Activation of Tuberculosis by Improvement Of Nutritional Status (RATIONS) trial could offer insight into the importance of nutritional interventions. RATIONS was done in Jharkhand with support from the Indian Council of Medical Research and was the first such trial of a food-based intervention. It aimed at reducing new TB cases in TB-affected families, and improving treatment outcomes for patients with TB.

Ramlal, a 19-year-old tribal boy in the trial, weighed only 26 kg and was almost bed-bound at the

time of his diagnosis of lung TB. Along with TB drugs, he received a monthly food basket. Over the next few weeks, he started walking and could cycle to work at the end of the treatment, weighing 42 kg. Laxmi, weighing 34 kg, had TB two years ago and had stopped medication after she developed jaundice within two weeks of starting anti-TB drugs. Now, as a result of the trial, she could adhere to the medications and also breastfeed her four-month-old.

Preventing deaths due to TB

Undernutrition, especially severe undernutrition, is common in patients in India. It is a major reversible risk factor for death, drug toxicity, and recurrence after successful treatment. For most patients with TB who are severely underweight, nutritional support is an essential and not optional part of treatment. Poor families are food-insecure and become even more so due to the disease. In the RATIONS trial, a monthly 10 kg food basket of cereals, pulses, milk powder, and oil led to a weight gain of almost 4.5 kg in patients. Even a 5% weight gain in the first two months was protective against



PM TB Mukta Bharath kits, which include basic nutritious food items, distributed to patients in Chittoor, Andhra Pradesh in 2023. FILE PHOTO

death, reducing the risk by more than 60%.

In India, the National TB Elimination Programme's (NTEP) initiatives in addressing undernutrition in TB care are welcome. For example, the monthly direct benefit transfer under the Ni-Kshay Poshan Yojana increased from ₹500 to ₹1,000 and similarly the Ni-Kshay Mitra Yojana, although not universal, provides in-kind support to patients with TB. However, the plan to introduce energy-dense nutrition supple-



ments for two months to underweight patients with TB needs to be considered with caution, given higher expenses, and the mystification of an adequate balanced diet apart from the risk of monotony and poor acceptability. One in 7 patients with TB in India may have diabetes which also needs to be taken into consideration.

A new avenue

While infection with the TB germ is necessary to develop the dis-

ease, it is not sufficient to produce active TB. Almost 90% of those infected, with good immunity, never develop the disease in their lifetime. Undernutrition is the most common cause of poor immunity in India and globally. It contributes to nearly 40% of new cases in India, and improved population-level nutritional status offers an alternative approach to reducing TB incidence.

Diets of the poor in India are particularly deficient in quality protein. TB-affected families experience vulnerabilities of poverty, food insecurity, and undernutrition. The 1.5 kg per month of pulses per family member, along with extra rice, worked like a vaccine in the RATIONS trial, with new TB cases in these families coming down by almost half.

The World Health Organization released new guidelines last year recommending nutritional interventions in settings of poverty and undernutrition, drawing significantly from the evidence of the RATIONS trial.

Improving nutrition security by including pulses in the public distribution system, and expanding the Ni-Kshay Mitra scheme to in-

clude TB patients' households will have long-term benefits in reducing the TB burden in India.

The way ahead

India is a global leader in implementing comprehensive nutrition assessment and support initiatives through the NTEP. Research and evidence from India have influenced global policy. Some of the next positive steps will be to record and report nutritional assessment at diagnosis; at two months; and at the end of treatment. This will help to identify those at risk of death, monitor early weight gain, and assess nutritional recovery. A differentiated TB care model in line with the TN-KET intervention in Tamil Nadu can identify and prioritise severely underweight patients. This will require local contextualisation of food baskets, with due attention given to comorbidities, supported by transport and inpatient care for the sick.

The inverse care law also works in TB and nutrition – the most vulnerable among us such as those in difficult-to-reach areas, the tribals, and the migrant workers, should not be left out.

The views expressed are personal.

Mental health of TB patients should not be overlooked

Studies from India have shown that at least one-third of people with TB experience symptoms of depression or anxiety



Dr. R. Thara

Co-Founder and Vice-Chair of the Schizophrenia Research Foundation (SCARF)

At least one in seven Indians experience a mental health condition at some point in their lives. In people with infectious diseases like Tuberculosis (TB) or HIV, this increases to anywhere between one-third to a half of those affected. TB takes a toll on not only physical but also mental health, either in the form of definite diagnosable conditions like depression, anxiety or psychoses or as emotional suffering worsened by social stigma. TB is fundamentally a disease of inequity, perpetuated by poverty and simultaneously contributing to increasing poverty. Unemployment, the lack of livelihood, food insecurity and malnutrition are social drivers for both TB and mental health conditions.

Studies from India have shown that at least one-third of people with TB experience symptoms of depression and anxiety, which often occur together as well. The mental health burden is estimated to be even higher among people with drug-resistant TB, with upto two-thirds having mental health issues. There are anecdotal accounts from TB survivors on suicidal ideation as well as

documented instances of people with TB dying by suicide. There is not enough evidence about the prevalence of severe mental illnesses such as schizophrenia or bipolar disorders in people affected by TB.

The stigma associated with TB remains pervasive, and includes self-stigma, stigma within families, at workplaces and within communities. Many TB survivors have spoken of the guilt and shame they feel on being diagnosed with TB, despite knowing that it is an airborne disease that can affect anyone. For those with pulmonary TB, the guilt is driven primarily by the fear of transmitting the disease within their families, particularly to children. Those with depression or anxiety and TB must cope with an increased burden of stigma associated with both conditions, which can further worsen mental health.

TB and mental health

Given the high prevalence of common mental health disorders in the general population, it is possible that depression or anxiety could have been pre-existing and unidentified, even prior to the TB diagnosis; there have not been



A doctor offers flowers to a TB patient in Agartala on World TB day. PTI

enough studies on this aspect. Depression or anxiety could delay care-seeking for TB. Long-standing untreated depression can also weaken the body's immune responses which in turn could lead to active TB disease – this is yet another under-researched aspect.

Post diagnosis, untreated mental health conditions can adversely affect TB treatment outcomes. A person with TB who is depressed, and has not received mental healthcare, is more likely to take TB treatment irregularly or discontinue treatment prematurely.

This can lead to treatment failure, relapse, or drug-resistance.

Co-existing alcohol and tobacco use, in the absence of access to de-addiction programmes, are also crucial factors affecting the treatment for TB.

Screening and identifying

Integrating routine screening for all people with TB for depression and anxiety is the starting point. Building awareness about common mental health disorders among healthcare workers, equipping them with the knowledge and

skills to provide mental health first-aid and ensuring early screening at the right point in the TB care cascade are the other essential steps. Primary healthcare workers and community supporters, who are often the first to notice any psychological distress, should be trained to elicit information about sleep, appetite, mood, stress etc. which can help early identification of mental health conditions.

Given that TB itself could trigger depression, mental health screening must ideally be done at multiple time points during the TB treatment period.

From an individual perspective, being treated for TB and depression at the same time can be a stressful experience. While India's TB programme already provides decentralised access to free anti-TB drugs and financial aid for nutrition, strengthening the availability of drugs to treat depression or anxiety through the district mental health programme is vital. While antidepressants or antipsychotics can be used alongside anti-TB drugs, clinicians must monitor for any adverse drug reactions or interactions. Psychological interventions, including cognitive-behavioural therapy and participation in peer support groups, can also help reduce isolation. To provide these services, qualified and trained mental health professionals are needed, particularly in rural and tribal areas.

Looking out for everyone

Mental health interventions cannot be limited to people with TB. The task of caring for people with TB can place considerable strain on families. Studies in India have shown that up to 80% of caregivers may exhibit high levels of Expressed negative Emotions (EE) and high stress levels due to their caregiving responsibilities. Often, high EE leads to increased caregiver burden and poorer treatment outcomes. In India's family-centred ecosystem, where most of the caregiving needs are met by family members, this can lead to critical or over-involved caregiving because of emotional, financial, and social strains.

Psychoeducation is important not just for persons with TB but also for their families and caregivers.

A blended and syndemic TB-mental health approach that considers mental healthcare as an essential part of TB care, rather than a standalone service, can significantly improve TB outcomes, reduce the burden on caregivers and improve long-term mental health.

THE HINDU

1 In million. More than 1,300 people have died from hunger in displacement camps in Ethiopia's volatile Tigray region over the past three years, a local official told AFP on Monday. A civil war between the federal government and forces from the northern Tigray region in 2020-2022 killed at least 600,000 people according to African Union estimates. AFP

COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

ABSTRACT

How do we know climate science is credible?

On what aspects did a recent paper in the Science of Climate Change journal question the foundations of climate change, and how robust are its arguments?

Vasudevan Mukunth

On March 10, a journal called Science of Climate Change published a paper calling into question the foundations of climate change. The paper concluded that after accounting for some sources of uncertainty in the climate data, the ‘correct’ changes in the oceans’ heat content and Earth’s energy imbalance are practically zero. In other words, the oceans are not warming, Earth’s surface is not accumulating heat, and global warming is not happening. The paper is more sophisticated than it seems at first sight and makes three claims with different levels of merit. There is value in addressing them in detail because doing so reveals how we know that climate science is credible.

How are changes in ocean heat measured? The paper’s foremost claim is that temperature is an intensive property – meaning its value does not depend on the mass of the material – and thus scientists cannot average it in a meaningful way when estimating the amount of heat oceans hold. Scientists have already addressed this claim. First, by the same logic, we cannot measure average air temperature, average atmospheric pressure, average sea level rise, and so on.

Second, and more importantly, scientists do not just measure and average the temperatures of different water bodies to determine the heat content. They also calculate the thermal energy. Temperature is nothing but the average kinetic energy of the atoms or molecules in a body. And thermal energy is the total kinetic energy of the water molecules. This is an extensive quantity – it depends on the number of molecules – and can be averaged. Its value has been increasing over time as well, and it also clarifies that the way scientists are handling the temperature data is correct.

Next, the paper takes issue with the Argo floats data. According to the U.S. National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration, “Argo is an international program that collects information from inside the ocean using free drifting [devices called] profiling floats. These floats drift with the ocean currents and move up and down between the surface and a mid-water level. The floats are distributed over the global ocean to measure temperature and salinity in the upper 2,000 m.” According to the paper, the data the floats collect have some gaps, which has created uncertainties in the final processed data that have gone underreported. To the paper’s credit, scientists have already raised and addressed the numbers it has cited on phenomena called mesoscale aliasing and deep ocean ignorance in the research literature. However, the paper’s authors inflate these uncertainties and add them up in unscientific ways. For instance, some of the errors they add up have the same underlying cause, so adding them as if they were separate errors ends up counting the same causes more than once.

To avoid this pitfall, oceanographers



Thinning ice: A penguin stands on an iceberg in Yankee Harbour, Antarctica in 2018. REUTERS

run the whole calculation in different ways and check whether they keep getting roughly the same answer. They check whether the calculation predicts temperatures at locations where they actually have measurements to compare with – and whether the overall estimate holds up when they remove data from the calculations. This way, they make sure their methods are robust and do not over-count uncertainties. Finally, if scientists have an independent estimate of total sea level rise (from altimetry satellites that use radar, say) and an independent estimate of how much new water has been added (from the GRACE satellites that use gravity), they can estimate how much the ocean has ‘expanded’. Then they compare this figure with Argo data about the ocean’s heat content. If the two match – as they do – it would mean Argo arrived at the same result as altimetry and GRACE (Gravity Recovery and Climate Experiment) satellites but from completely different starting points.

What is ‘Balancing’ and ‘Filling’? Finally, the paper says the CERES-Argo cross-calibration is “circular”. This is probably the most rhetorically effective

piece for ‘climate doubters’ because it genuinely sounds damning. However, that is really because it misrepresents what a particular ‘adjustment’ does. CERES is a suite of scientific instruments in Earth orbit operated by NASA. Its name stands for ‘Clouds and the Earth’s Radiant Energy System’. The instruments measure incoming solar radiation and outgoing shortwave radiation (which includes visible light) and longwave radiation (mostly heat) at the top of the atmosphere. By subtracting the incoming rate of energy from the outgoing rate, scientists can say how much heat is being ‘left behind’ in the planet’s atmosphere and on the surface. Now, the CERES instruments have been calibrated such that they are accurate to around 1% for shortwave radiation and 0.75% for longwave. This implies an absolute uncertainty of roughly 2 W/m2 in the net energy flux. The paper says the raw CERES uncertainty is around 3-5 W/m2, which is slightly inflated in favour of the paper’s claims. To address this, a process called EBAF – short for ‘Energy Balanced And Filled’ – makes a one-time change to shortwave and longwave fluxes at the top of the

atmosphere to ensure the global mean net flux for July 2005 to June 2015 is consistent with the value measured by Argo: 0.71 W/m2. ‘Balancing’ and ‘Filling’ are separate adjustments. CERES instruments cannot see through clouds, so ‘Filling’ patches gaps in the map where data is missing. However, the paper treats the whole EBAF product as if it is just the adjustment for calibration, i.e. ‘Balancing’. Nonetheless, as things stand, the paper’s circularity argument is partly correct: CERES data is ‘corrected’ using Argo data while Argo-derived estimates of the oceans’ heat content are validated using CERES data.

What does CERES do? But then the paper goes wrong. The ‘Balance’ of EBAF only adjusts the mean energy flux. It does not interact in any way with the increases and drops in the temperature data over time. That comes from the CERES instruments’ raw data and is what contains evidence of the warming trend. Specifically, the CERES instruments continuously measure the radiation coming from the Sun into the atmosphere and the outgoing longwave and shortwave radiation at the top of the atmosphere. Then computers produce a monthly global mean net flux value for every month from March 2000 to the present. These raw monthly data are off from the 0.7 W/m2 measured by Argo, so EBAF ‘adds’ or ‘subtracts’ some flux from every monthly value in the record to bring the long-period mean in line with the Argo estimate. The monthly values after this adjustment are thus higher or lower than the raw values by exactly the same amount in every single month. This means the difference between any two months – March 2005 and March 2015, say – is unaffected by EBAF. For example, if EBAF adds 3.6 W/m2 to the measured values, the difference between 4 and 5 in the raw data is the same as the difference between 7.6 and 8.6 in the processed data, which is 1 W/m2. The idea that Earth’s energy imbalance has been increasing over the satellite record is based on these differences, which Argo data is unconcerned with. As a result, the circularity objection proves less than what the paper has claimed it does.

What sustains credibility? For added measure, scientists have also estimated Earth’s energy imbalance (outgoing minus incoming) using atmospheric reanalyses, deep ocean temperature records from research vessels, and physical models informed by observed surface warming – all of which have been consistent with the CERES-Argo figures. If the imbalance were actually zero, the independent estimates would all have to be wrong for independent reasons. And the odds of that are extremely low. In fact, the answer to whether the paper could be right is not that one of its authors is a “clarinet instructor” (which he was at the time he worked on the paper), that its rhetoric is often obscurantist, that some of its other authors have done questionable things in the past or even that it has not passed peer-review by a “prestigious” journal. It is that the paper does not perform any independent tests of the data the way credible studies do. That is in fact the bedrock of the credibility of climate science as a whole. And any efforts that claim to overturn that must also convincingly explain how independent checks arrived at the same result while being flawed in independent ways.



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

“What did you do on New Year’s Eve? Did you have fun?” “Oh, yes! I had a great deal of fun! My friends and I danced till 4:00 in the morning. And as you can imagine, I was dead beat after that. I found it....” “....you were beat? Who beat you? And why?” “Nobody beat me! All that dancing had me beat. You see, when you say that you’re beat, it implies that you are extremely tired. It’s one of the meanings of the word ‘beat’.” “I see. It’s an informal expression, I suppose?” “That’s right! It’s not used in formal contexts. Here’s an example. The college students were dead beat after the long trek.” “Vyomekesh looked dead beat after doing his karate exercises.” “That’s a good example. Agarkar looked beat after bowling his tenth over.” “I don’t really agree with you. He doesn’t usually look beat after bowling ten overs. It’s just that he always looks as if he wants to sit down and cry.” “That’s true. He always looks sad, doesn’t he?” “Most of our cricketers do. And the way they are playing, they are making everyone in the country sad, too. Tell me, is there another word which means ‘tired’? An informal word, I mean.” “Sure, there is. ‘Bushed’ is another word used in informal contexts to mean ‘tired’. After playing the third set, Ramdas was bushed.” “When Mala asked me if I was interested in going to the movies, I told her I was too bushed to go. How does that sound?” “Sounds good.” “Hey, doesn’t the word ‘stressed out’ mean the same thing as ‘bushed’?” “Not really. You see,” “....what do you mean? Doesn’t ‘stressed out’ mean tired too?” “Well, yes. But there is a difference between being ‘stressed out’ and being ‘bushed’. You see, when you say you are ‘bushed’ or ‘beat’, what you are implying is that you are physically exhausted.” “I see. And when you say that you are ‘stressed out’ it means that you are mentally exhausted. Am I right?” “I guess you could say that. ‘Stressed out’ is more mental than physical. For example, studying for the GRE has really stressed out Suresh.” “Talking to my uncle for five minutes stresses me out.” “I am sure my nephews say the same thing.” “When I was young, sitting in maths class used to stress me out.” “I still have nightmares thinking about my maths class.” “My friend Suresh gets asthma thinking about maths.” “Gets what?” “A...s...t...h...m...a. Asthma!” “The ‘th’ in the word ‘asthma’ is not pronounced.” “It isn’t?” “....the ‘as’ in the first syllable is like the word ‘ass’. The final ‘a’ is like the ‘a’ in ‘china’, ‘about’, and ‘amount’.” “The ‘th’ is not pronounced at all and the stress is on the first syllable. Correct?” “Excellent. Some people pronounce the ‘s’ in the first syllable like the ‘z’ in ‘zip’, ‘zest’, and ‘zoo’.” Published in The Hindu on January 4, 2000

THE DAILY QUIZ

On the anniversary of the execution of three young revolutionaries on March 23, 1931, revisit one of the most debated moments in India’s freedom struggle

Prathmesh Kher

- QUESTION 1 The execution of Bhagat Singh, Sukhdev Thapar and Shivaram Rajguru followed their conviction in which case related to the assassination of John Saunders in Lahore?
- QUESTION 2 The assassination of Saunders was intended as retaliation for the police assault on which nationalist leader who later died of injuries sustained during a lathi charge?
- QUESTION 3 In which prison were the three revolutionaries executed?
- QUESTION 4 Which pact between nationalist leaders and the British government was signed shortly before the executions in 1931?
- QUESTION 5 What was the title of the editorial published after the executions, by B. R. Ambedkar in the Marathi weekly Janata, on April 13, 1931?



Identify this Indian revolutionary, commander-in-chief of the Hindustan Socialist Republican Association, who died in a gun battle with the British police at Alfred Park in 1931. PUBLIC DOMAIN

- Questions and answers to the previous day’s daily quiz: 1. The World Meteorological Organization is headquartered in this European city. **Ans: Geneva, Switzerland**
2. Expand GRIB, the concise data format commonly used in meteorology. **Ans: General Regularly-distributed Information in Binary form**
3. To a meteorologist, an ‘okta’, a scale of measurement is. **Ans: The amount of cloud cover at any given location**
4. The term for rain that falls from a cloud but evaporates before reaching the ground, seen as streaks under a cloud. **Ans: Virga**
5. Parts of Kerala witnessed ‘blood rain’ as recently as 2012. Name its prime cause. **Ans: Aerial spores of the orange-coloured ‘Trentepohlia’ algae, often triggered by atmospheric conditions**
6. The everyday two-word term for strong, high-altitude wind band that pilots use to save time and fuel on long flights. **Ans: Jet Stream**
7. The recurring natural phenomenon characterised by fluctuating ocean temperatures in the equatorial Pacific is the ENSO. Expand ENSO. **Ans: El Niño-Southern Oscillation**
- Visual: Name the Indian scientist who in his capacity as the chairman of the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC) received the Nobel Peace Prize, along with Al Gore, in 2007. **Ans: Rajendra Pachauri**
- Early birds: Piyali Tuli | K.N. Viswanathan | Prem Nath Tiwari | Sukdev Shet | Ashok Tripathi

Please send in your answers to
dailyquiz@thehindu.co.in

Word of the day

Boisterous: noisy and lacking in restraint or discipline

Synonyms: rambunctious, unruly

Usage: The crowd grew boisterous as the match reached its final moments.

Pronunciation: https://newsth.live/ZQEJN5

International Phonetic Alphabet: /ˈbɔɪstəʃəs/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to letters@thehindu.co.in with the subject ‘Text & Context’

From Page One

Trump pauses strikes on Iran, says deal is possible

“Our people demand the complete and humiliating punishment of the aggressors. All officials stand firmly behind their Leader and people until this goal is achieved”, the Iranian Speaker said in a social media post on Monday.

In recent days, friendly countries sent messages indicating that the U.S. had requested talks to end the war, but Iran had not responded, Iran's state news agency *IRNA* quoted its Foreign Ministry spokesperson as saying. “Yes, there have been initiatives from regional countries to reduce tensions, and our response to all of them is clear: we are not the party that started this war, and all such requests should be directed to Washington,” state-run *Mizan* agency cited the Foreign Ministry.

‘Constructive conversations’

“Based on the tenor and tone of these in-depth, detailed, and constructive conversations, which [which] will continue throughout the week, I have instructed the Department of War to postpone any and all military strikes against Iranian power plants and energy infrastructure for a five day period, subject to the success of the ongoing meetings and discussions,” Mr. Trump wrote in his post.

“All I am saying is, we are in the throes of a real possibility of making a deal... We are dealing with the man who I believe is the most respected and the leader,” Mr. Trump said in Washington, without saying who the U.S. was speaking with but added that it was not the Supreme Leader Ayatollah Mojtaba Khamenei. “Look at Venezuela, how well that’s working out... Maybe we find somebody like that in Iran,” he said, adding that the U.S. wants Iran to abandon any nuclear ambitions and give up its enriched uranium stockpiles.

Women’s quota: Centre mulls early delimitation

As per Article 82 of the Constitution, the next delimitation exercise was to be done based on the first Census after 2026, but these amendments could mean that the 2011 Census data will be applied and the remaking of constituencies can proceed without the current Census exercise being concluded. The proposals may include the expansion of State Assemblies as well.

The Act originally passed in September 2023 envisaged the conduct of the Decadal Census, followed by delimitation of seats. The 2021 Decadal Census, which got delayed because of COVID, beginning next month. As per the current timelines, implementation of the Act could be pushed beyond 2030. However, by bringing in fresh amendments, the government is now seeking to bring forward the implementation of the Act.

Government managers, including Union Home Minister Amit Shah, met with leaders of several Opposition parties on Monday, including the Nationalist Congress Party (SP)’s Supriya Sule, YSR Congress Party’s P.V. Midhun Reddy, the All India Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen’s Asaduddin Owaisi and the Shiv Sena (UBT)’s Arvind Sawant, among others. Trinamool Congress and the Left skipped the meeting.

A separate meeting of NDA partners was held later on Monday evening. The government managers had consulted the Congress and Samajwadi Party earlier. The Congress will be holding a meeting of Opposition floor leaders on Tuesday morning to go through the proposals put forward by the government.

“The amendments will require a two-thirds majority of both Houses, which is why extensive consultations are being held with the Opposition...,” said a government source.

The Women’s Reservation Act, 2023, known as the Constitution (106th Amendment) Act, 2023, mandates a 33% reservation for women in the Lok Sabha and State Assemblies.

‘U.S.-led Pax Silica is a step towards digital colonialism’

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Senior Congress MP Digvijaya Singh on Monday warned the Union government against joining Pax Silica, terming the U.S.-led project a step towards digital colonialism.

The U.S.-led initiative is aimed at building resilient supply chains for critical minerals and Artificial Intelligence (AI) technologies. India joined the coalition in February 2026, during the AI Impact summit held in New Delhi.

Raising the matter during Zero Hour in the Rajya Sabha on Monday, Mr. Singh asked the government to make the terms and conditions of the agreement public.

BJP hails Modi for becoming India’s longest-serving head of government

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Monday hailed Prime Minister Narendra Modi for becoming India’s longest-serving head of government, surpassing the 8,930-day record earlier held by former Sikkim Chief Minister Pawan Chamling.

At a press conference, on the party’s behalf, Union Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan expressed gratitude to the Prime Minister for India’s powerful representation in the changing global landscape, stating that Mr. Modi has taken the country to new heights.

“Narendra Modi *ji* is not just a leader, but also a visionary and an institution in himself, who has consistently worked for national

Impact of West Asia war likely to be felt for long time, PM tells Lok Sabha

Country should be prepared and united, says Modi as he condemns attacks on commercial ships and obstruction of Strait of Hormuz; India has 5.3 million tonnes of petrol reserves, and govt. is working towards increasing this to 6.5 million tonnes

Sandeep Phukan
NEW DELHI

The situation in West Asia is “deeply concerning”, and the impact of the war is likely to be felt for a long time, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said on Monday, while briefing the Lok Sabha on the steps taken by his government to secure India’s energy needs.

The country should be prepared and united, Mr. Modi said, urging all members to ensure the Indian Parliament sends out a “united and unanimous voice on the issue”.

The government should hold a proper discussion so that other members can put forth their views, Congress MP Priyanka Gandhi Vadra said after the Prime Minister’s speech.

Earlier, making a statement in the Lok Sabha, Mr. Modi said he had spoken to the heads of most West



Every Indian in the war-affected region is being given every possible help, Narendra Modi informed in Parliament on Monday. SANSAD TV

Asian countries, all of whom had assured the safety of Indians.

“India has always raised its voice for peace in the interest of humanity. Dialogue and diplomacy are the solutions to this problem. Our efforts are aimed at reducing tensions and ending this conflict,” Mr. Modi said, amid the thumping of desks by ruling party members.

“I myself have spoken with all relevant leaders in West Asia. I have urged

pliers from various countries to ensure that oil and gas supplies continued from wherever possible, he said, addressing apprehensions of fuel shortages. All power plants in the country have adequate stocks of coal, he added.

India has 5.3 million tonnes of strategic petroleum reserves, and the government was working towards increasing this to 6.5 million tonnes, he told the House.

“The reserves maintained by our oil companies are separate. In the past 11 years, our refining capacity has also increased significantly,” Mr. Modi added.

The country’s farmers had filled the food grain reserves, so India is well prepared in terms of food security, he said, speaking on the war’s impact on agriculture.

“We are also making efforts to ensure that kharif sowing takes place proper-

ly. For this, the government has made adequate arrangements for fertilizers to deal with any emergency...,” he said.

As summer has begun in India, the demand for electricity has increased, but all power plants in the country have adequate stocks of coal, he said.

West Asia is important to India as nearly one crore Indians live and work in the Gulf countries, the Prime Minister added.

Every Indian in the war-affected region was being given every possible help, and more than 3.75 lakh Indians, including 1,000 people from war-torn Iran, had been safely evacuated, Mr. Modi said.

However, several lives had been lost, and some people had been injured during the conflict, the Prime Minister said, adding that their families were being given the necessary help.

India tracking developments, says Centre on Trump pause

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

India is closely monitoring developments, External Affairs Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said on Monday shortly after U.S. President Donald Trump announced that he would postpone attacks on Iran’s power infrastructure for five days.

Another senior official termed the move “positive”, while emphasising that the government was keeping an eye on the developments.

On Monday evening, External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar held talks with the Ambassadors of the GCC countries, namely Bahrain, Kuwait, Oman, Qatar, Saudi Arabia, and the UAE. He said he “thanked them for their continued support to the Indian community in the region”. He also spoke over the telephone to Sri Lankan Foreign Minister Vijitha Herath about developments in the war.

Kashmiri Pandits ask Muslims to ensure their return to J&K

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

Kashmiri Pandits on Monday asked Kashmiri Muslims to come forward and pave way for the return of the displaced minority community as they gathered in the Valley to pay tributes to the 24 Pandits who were killed by terrorists on March 23, 2003 in south Kashmir’s Pulwama.

Scores of Pandits and Muslims swarmed the venue at Nadimarg and paid floral tributes. “We observe March 23 as black day. Till our last breath, we will remember the victims. We will not forgive or forget those who carried out the heinous crime,” said a Kashmiri Pandit, who had travelled to Kashmir specially for paying the tributes.

Referring to the migration of Kashmiri Pandits from the Valley in the 1990s, he said, “It has been a long time now. Pandits have a microscopic population of around 4% in Kashmir. It is time for the Muslim population to come forward for our return.”

Two more Indian vessels carrying 93,000 tonnes of LPG cross Strait of Hormuz

M. Kalyanaraman
CHENNAI

Two Indian-flagged LPG carriers, *Jag Vasant* and *Pine Gas*, have transited through the Strait of Hormuz on Monday evening. They are together carrying nearly 93,000 tonnes of LPG, as per the inter-Ministerial briefing held on Monday. In addition, a flurry of LPG import shipments that came in the past few days and scheduled for the upcoming week may have eased the cooking gas crisis somewhat.

In a sign of the easing crisis, the government had announced a 20% increase in commercial LPG allocations, taking it to 50% of pre-war levels even while saying the LPG situation continues to be worrisome.

Jag Vasant and *Pine Gas*, owned by Great Eastern Shipping and Seven Island Shipping respectively, are likely to reach Indian ports between March 26 and 28. The government had said that domestic LPG production had increased by 40%, which would mean an additional 18,000 tonnes pro-



People in a queue with empty LPG cooking gas cylinders to avail refilled ones in Prayagraj.

duction a day, bringing down the approximate daily import requirement from 55,000 tonnes. At normal times, India would need at least one Very Large Gas Carrier of some 55,000 tonnes to dock at one of its ports every day and discharge the cargo.

Two foreign-owned and foreign-flagged LPG carriers, *Hellas Gladiator* and *Gas Jupiter*, each carrying 24,000 tonnes are expected to reach Visakhapatnam on March 30.

Hellas Gladiator had loaded in Netherlands. Port sources say that this shipment is part of the strategic decision to source LPG from European markets to bypass the ongoing supply constraints in West

Asia. *Gas Jupiter* loaded its cargo in the U.S.

The cavern project of SA-LPG at Visakhapatnam, which is one of India’s two long-term LPG storage locations, had handled two ships carrying LPG after February 28. Each ship carried and unloaded about 24,000 tonnes. The total capacity of the cavern is 60,000 tonnes and is one of two long-term LPG storage facilities in India.

Globe Polarix, carrying cargo from Houston, Texas, is expected to reach Sandhead, Kolkata, on March 24, according to an official in Haldia port.

It will berth the following day and discharge more than 20,000 tonnes in all.

BW Birch, carrying LPG taken from *Nanda Devi* in Vadinar Port in Gujarat through ship-to-ship transfer, is expected to dock at Haldia on March 29 and discharge cargo.

Gas Jupiter is also expected on April 3 at Haldia. (Inputs from Sumit Bhattacharjee, Sunita Sekar, Anil Kumar Sastri, Satyasundar Barik, Dhinesh Kallungal and Lalatendu Mishra)

Anil Ambani bank fraud case: ‘CBI, ED showed reluctance’

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI



Anil Ambani

The Supreme Court on Monday said the Directorate of Enforcement (ED) and the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) must probe the financial fraud allegations linked to Anil Dhirubhai Ambani Group (ADAG) and promoter Anil Ambani in a “transparent, fair and credible manner”, while making a note that the probe agencies’ previous conduct had shown “reluctance” and lack of discipline or structure.

“...your investigative agencies, the way they have shown reluctance and allowed things to go whichever way... that is not acceptable. The investigation should be done in a transparent, fair and credible manner.” Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, heading a three-judge Bench, addressed Solicitor-General Tushar Mehta.

“Your investigation must inspire confidence not only of the court, but of every stakeholder. People should be convinced that you have done a fair and completely independent investigation,” the

Chief Justice told Mr. Mehta. The Supreme Court observed that “probe agencies must join hands and make rigorous attempts to unearth the irregularities, illegalities or connivance of the public functionaries, especially financial institutions, if any”.

“We are making no opinion on the merits of allegations. The CBI and the ED have to complete the probe in a most dispassionate, fair, transparent and independent manner, and take it to a logical conclusion in a time-bound manner... All financial agencies have to extend full cooperation to the ED. In case of any delay or reluctance, the ED must make a submission to this court,” the Supreme Court advised.

‘Biotech industry driving both human and animal nutrition’

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Biotechnology graduates are the architects of the next animal science revolution in the country, experts said at a webinar on “Biotech Careers: Food and Nutrition” on Sunday.

The webinar was jointly organised by the Vellore Institute of Technology, Chennai, and *The Hindu* as part of the series titled “Biotechnology: Role in Industry 5.0 – Sustainable Future Pathways”.

“While the growth rate of the food processing market is estimated at 13%, India’s bio-economy rate is projected to be much higher. This means biotechnology students will have enough career opportunities to steer the growth over the next decade,” Anand



K. Jadi, general manager and plant head, ICML Medak, ITC Ltd., said.

G. Jayaraman, Professor and Dean of the School of Biosciences and Technology at VIT, Chennai, spoke about biotechnology’s increasing influence in various sectors, including agriculture, food, healthcare, and research-driven innovation. He said the biotech industry was driving both human and animal nutrition. “It is enhancing the quality and

quantity of food.”

Chakkaravarthi Saravanan, Associate Professor at the National Institute of Food Technology, Entrepreneurship and Management in Kundli, Haryana, pointed out that with an ever-increasing population, shrinking land space, and rising food prices, the significance of biotechnology for food was growing.

Speaking on the role of biotechnology in the livestock industry, R. Balaguru, technical director at V.K. Palappa Nadar Poultry Farms Pvt. Ltd., said 70% of the rural poor in the world depended on livestock. The panellists advocated for establishing a solid foundation for learning new-age technologies.

The webinar can be viewed at <https://newsth.live/THVITFNY>

Gaurav Gogoi enters electoral fray from Jorhat

A photograph showing a large crowd of people, likely supporters of the BJP, celebrating. Many individuals are wearing red and white striped scarves, a symbol associated with the party. Several people have their fists raised in the air, and there are Indian national flags visible in the background. The scene appears to be outdoors during a public gathering or rally.

JMM to go solo, releases list for Assam election



AIMIM to ally with Humayun Kabir's AJUP



*With a catla,
BJP candidate
has a bone
to pick with
Trinamool*

People will assess governance failure, corruption and favour UDF: KPCC chief

Almost half of the SIR cases under adjudication settled in Bengal: CEO

Stage set for battle of the turncoats in high-stakes Dispur

CM
Y
K

INBRIEF



Oil plunges after strikes on Iranian power plants put off

Oil prices plunged by more than 13% on Monday after U.S. President Donald Trump said he would postpone any military strikes against Iranian power plants for five days, hours ahead of a deadline that threatened further escalation in the conflict now in its fourth week. Brent crude futures traded at about \$104.1 a barrel, or down 7.2%, at 11.30 GMT after sliding as much as 15% to a session low of \$96 a barrel. REUTERS

Centre restores RoDTEP benefits for exporters

The government has restored the complete benefits provided to exporters under the Remission of Duties and Taxes on Exported Products (RoDTEP) scheme. In a notification it said the rates and values applicable on February 22 this year and were reduced by 50% are now being restored to earlier levels from February 23 to March 31. According to GTRI, while the DGFT decision is welcome, the initial reduction is hard to justify as RoDTEP is not a subsidy.

Avoid insinuations without any evidence, says SEBI chief

In the wake of the crisis at the HDFC Bank which was triggered by the sudden exit of Chairman Atanu Chakraborty, Securities and Exchange Board of India chairperson Tuhin Kanta Pandey said on Monday that insinuations without any evidence should be avoided. Speaking at a media briefing post the regulator's Q4 FY26 board meeting, Mr. Pandey highlighted the responsibilities of independent directors in matters of actual or suspected fraud.

SEBI board okays conflict of interest panel's key recommendations

Ashokamithran T.
MUMBAI

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) has decided to approve key recommendations of the High Level Committee on Conflict of Interest..

According to the board, the recommendations include bringing the chairperson and whole time board members within the definition of an 'insider', establishing digital systems for conflict-of-interest management and a new office of ethics and compliance to oversee public issues. SEBI also recommended notifying separate regulations for board members and an oversight committee on ethics to oversee board members.



Ease of doing business: FPIs will now be allowed to settle funds on a net basis for stock market transactions. REUTERS

Another major regulatory change approved was to simplify 'fit and proper person' norms for intermediaries, which include depositories, clearing houses and exchanges. Accordingly, members of intermediaries would be disqualified only on conviction for eco-

nom ic offences or securities law violation. However, grounds for disqualification would also include offences involving moral turpitude.

The board also decided Foreign Portfolio Investors (FPIs) will now be allowed to settle funds on a net ba-

sis for stock market transactions viz. payment for a stock FPIs buy would be adjusted against the proceeds of the stock it sells.

Earlier, FPIs had to pay for the stock they bought in full and receive payment for the stocks they sold.

Cutting cost

When FPI outflows had crossed ₹88,000 crore in March alone, SEBI Chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey assured new FPI registrations continued in response to steps easing their operations and cutting cost. The board also reduced minimum investment value for social impact funds in Alternative Investment Funds to ₹1,000 from ₹2 lakh to boost retail participation.



Earlier 90% LPG was from West Asia, Ms. Sharma said.

Asia," she stated.

The senior official emphasised domestic LPG supplies were 'normal as before.' "Panic bookings, which peaked to 88 lakh, has come down to about 50 lakhs. So, it has come to

normal," she said.

Migration to PNG

She said about 1.90 lakh consumers had migrated from LPG to PNG. Cumulatively more than 3.5 lakh domestic and commercial PNG connections had been issued or activated in the first three weeks of March.

For perspective, amid the escalating tensions, the Union Government had been encouraging for a transition to piped natural gas (PNG) from the cooking gas cylinders.

'Techno-commercial'

On India potentially tapping into market for Iranian crude oil, she held, "I

Lok Sabha sends Corporate Law Amendment Bill 2026 to JPC

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The government introduced the Corporate Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026 in the Lok Sabha following which the House adopted a motion to send the proposed legislation to a Joint Parliamentary Committee (JPC) for detailed examination.

The JPC will comprise members from both Houses of Parliament for detailed analysis and recommendations, Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman said while proposing the motion for JPC reference. The motion was adopted by a voice vote.

The Bill seeks further amendments to the Limited Liability Partnership



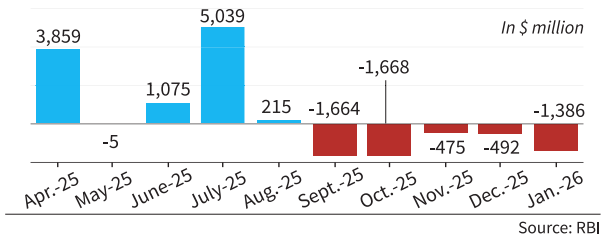
Nirmala Sitharaman

Act, 2008 and the Companies Act, 2013 to facilitate ease of doing business and address the gaps identified by the Company Law Committee in its 2022 report.

The proposed amendments are expected to rationalise penalties, shift several minor procedural lapses from criminal liabili-

Flowing out

Net FDI into India was negative for the fifth consecutive month in January 2026 due to high levels of repatriation by foreign companies in India



Net FDI negative for fifth straight month

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

Net FDI into India contracted for the fifth consecutive month in January 2026, with outflows exceeding inflows by nearly \$1.4 billion, a three-month high. The data shows this was because inflows into India fell nearly 7% while the amount repatriated out of the country nearly doubled.

According to data released by the Reserve Bank of India on Monday as part of its monthly bulletin, the total amount of money entering India as direct investment, or gross FDI, stood at about \$5.7 billion in January 2026.

This was 7% lower than in January last year, and only two-thirds of the amount that came in December 2025. The RBI, however, looked at a longer time period to draw some positive conclusions.

"During April 2025 - January 2026, gross FDI inflows remained strong, higher than the corresponding period a year ago," the central bank noted in its report. "Sector-wise, manufacturing re-

ceived the highest share of equity inflows, followed by computer services, electricity and other energy, and financial services – these sectors together accounted for over 60% of total inflows."

With regard to outflows, the outward FDI by Indian companies increased by 5.4% in January 2026 to \$2.1 billion. This was, however, nearly 30% lower than the outward FDI in December 2025.

"Around 75% of the outward FDI flows were directed to the U.S., Singapore, the UK, and the UAE during the [April 2025 - January 2026] period," the RBI said. Repatriation and disinvestment by foreign companies doing business in India, on the other hand, increased by 97.3% to \$4.9 billion in January 2026. But this was nearly 18% lower than the amount in December 2025.

As a result, net FDI stood at about -\$1.4 billion, the lowest since October 2025.

The central bank noted that portfolio investments again flowed out more than they flowed in in March this year.

Wipro expands footprint in South Korea

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Wipro announced the expansion of its business operations in South Korea. This would include: an enlarged office footprint in Seoul, unveiling a new Innovation Lab as part of the Wipro Innovation Network (WIN), and continued investment in local talent to support South Korean clients locally and globally.

This reflected the growing importance of Korea in shaping global innovation and increasing demand from South Korean enterprises for AI-led transformation, said Wipro.

Local LPG output now at 50-60% of consumption requirement: official

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Local production of liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) is fulfilling about 50-60% of domestic demand, Sujata Sharma, Joint-Secretary at the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas (MoPNG) told reporters at the daily inter-Ministerial briefing on West Asia situation.

Responding to queries about the geographies India is procuring LPG from, Ms. Sharma held the country was picking up cargoes from wherever available.

"We require a whole lot of LPG now, and because earlier 90% of our imports were coming from West

'Prolonged war detrimental to broader global outlook'

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

Prolonged war and high uncertainty would be detrimental to the broader global outlook, which was already in a state of flux prior to the recent events, Reserve Bank of India (RBI) officials said in the March edition of RBI Bulletin.

External dependence

"For the domestic economy, given India's external dependence on crude oil, the evolving situation requires close monitoring and proactive measures to limit adverse spillovers even though it is mention worthy the capacity and



Evolving situation requires close monitoring, officials said.

resilience of the Indian economy to absorb external shocks have strengthened over time, buttressed by its strong growth, sound macroeconomic fundamentals and robust external sector buff-

ers," they emphasised. Stating that in terms of energy security, India progressively diversified its crude oil import sources and augmented domestic refining capacity, they said since the start of the conflict, several policy steps had been implemented to blunt the immediate impact of the disruptions in global fuel supply chains and achieve more effective use of domestic capacity to meet shortfalls.

The creation of an Economic Stabilisation Fund would further provide fiscal headroom and buffer to proactively respond to global headwinds, the officials pointed out.

Setback to Meloni as Italian voters reject plans to overhaul judiciary



Pakistan vows to root out terrorism as Afghan Taliban truce nears end



Statue of Christopher Columbus installed on White House grounds



Slovenia headed towards coalition talks after tight election outcome



Gulf nations targeted in new attacks; Iran threatens to mine access routes

Runway collision kills two pilots at New York airport

IEA chief warns oil shock worse than 1970s crises

Taiwan Opposition leader says talks with Xi a 'bridge' to peace

North Korea's Kim reappointed as President of state affairs: state media


GOVERNMENT OF ANDHRA PRADESH
ROADS & BUILDINGS DEPARTMENT
INVITATION FOR BIDS
IFB.No.1/ENC(R&B) MDR&NDB/PIU/2025-26 **Dt:16-03-2026.**
 1. Online Bids are invited from eligible individual consultants for appointment as
 (1) **Finance Management Expert** & (2) **Environmental Expert** in the Project
 Implementation Unit (PIU) for the **APRRBP** and **APMCIRC** projects, implemented
 with loan assistance from the **New Development Bank (NDB)**,
 2. The Request for Proposal (**RFP**) document can be downloaded from the Central
 e-procurement place i.e., "<https://procure.gov.in/procure/app/>" from **25.03.2026**
 from **3.00 PM** onwards. The last date and time of submission of bids is on or before
24.04.2026 up to 3.00 PM.
 3. Further details can be seen on Central e-procurement market place i.e.,
 "<https://procure.gov.in/procure/app/>",
DIPR 4928/PPC, Dt: 23/03/2026 **Sd/- for Engineer-in-Chief (R&B), MDR & NDB**

ROLE CLARITY

Rahul will open the batting, says Delhi Capitals captain Axar



FILE PHOTO: SHIV KUMAR PUSHAKAR

Delhi Capitals captain Axar Patel said that the versatile K.L. Rahul will open the batting in the upcoming IPL season. “Last year, Rahul was playing in the middle-order because of our team combination. He has always been good in the opening slot, he has hit a lot of runs. I think we will keep him as an opener,” said Axar on Monday.

TOUGH LUCK

Disappointed to lose a player of Curran’s calibre: Sangakkara



AP

RR head coach Kumar Sangakkara expressed disappointment at Sam Curran missing IPL 2026. “We are disappointed to lose a player of Sam’s calibre so close to the start of the season. Sam brings immense value with both bat and ball. However, we are pleased to have found an ideal replacement in Dasun Shanaka,” he added.

READY TO FIRE

Fit-and-raring Rohit will really take it on in IPL 2026, reckons Ashwin



FILE PHOTO: R.V. MOORTHY

I think this is going to be a season where Rohit (Sharma) will really take it on. He is getting enough breaks. His mind is fresh. He is physically in a good space. He looks really fit. This could well be a season where Rohit is going to bring back his T20 batting in the IPL — R. Ashwin.

CELEBRATORY MOOD

Gujarat Titans sets the tone for the season ahead in a gala event



VIJAY SONEJI

Gujarat Titans set the tone for the upcoming IPL season as its players, staff, franchise owners, partners and fans came together for ‘Shubharambh 2026’, a gala event in Ahmedabad on Monday. Shubman Gill, the team’s captain, was recognised keeping in mind the broader narrative of consistency, growth, and ambition.



Distinguished career: Thyagarajan joined *The Hindu* on June 6, 1962, rose through the ranks, and retired as the Deputy Sports Editor on December 21, 2013. THE HINDU ARCHIVES

S. Thyagarajan, doyen of sports journalism, passes away

Sports Bureau
CHENNAI



S. Thyagarajan.

S. Thyagarajan, 85, veteran sports correspondent, who worked with *The Hindu* for more than five decades, passed away here on Monday. A multi-sport writer, who eventually specialised in covering hockey, Thyagarajan, “Thyagu Sir” for many, was the spine that held *The Hindu’s* sports department together for many years.

He joined the organisation on June 6, 1962, rose through the ranks, and retired as the Deputy Sports Editor on December 21, 2013. For an additional year, he also worked as a consultant with *The Hindu* Group. Through his career, he wrote extensively in *The Hindu* and *Sportstar*.

Known for an alliterative style, Thyagarajan weighed his words, and reported sport, ranging from the hyper-local to the Olympics, with accuracy. He was a regular presence in most press boxes across the globe, and always ready with a quick repartee.

Having reported multiple Olympics and Asian Games, he also covered almost all hockey matches that involved India for decades. His analysis had depth and his criticism was always linked to the sport and the way it was played, and never got personal. Right from the junior athlete to a champion like

Dhanraj Pillay, from a local club official to senior sports administrators, Thyagarajan’s connections spanned a wide range and in all these circles, he was held in high regard.

Even after retirement, he kept a watch on *The Hindu’s* sports pages. If he liked a feature or report, he would text a warm message. And if there was a new byline, he would be curious to know about the writer. Accessible and a fount of innumerable anecdotes, he would often delve into the past and recount tales with gusto.

Thyagarajan is survived by wife and two daughters. Hockey India, the Sports Journalists Federation of India (SJFI) and the Tamil Nadu Sports Journalists Association (TNSJA) condoled his demise. He was the SJFI president in the 1990s. Thyagarajan was also one of the founding members of the TNSJA and served honourably as its president.

SNAPSHOTS

Arundhati, Farhan win ICC Player-of-the-Month awards for February
India medium-pacer Arundhati Reddy won the ICC Player of the Month (women) award for her fine performances in the T20I series in Australia. Pakistan opener Sahibzada Farhan bagged the men’s award for his record-breaking show in the T20 World Cup.



Arundhati.
FILE PHOTO: NIRMAL HARINDRAN

Stokes and McCullum to remain in charge
England coach Brendon McCullum will keep his job despite the team’s Ashes debacle, with cricket chief Richard Gould insisting he can “adapt and evolve”. The

ECB promised a “thorough review” after Ben Stokes’ team was demolished 1-4 on its five-Test tour of Australia. Captain Stokes, McCullum, and England managing director of men’s cricket Rob Key will all keep their jobs.

Playing with ‘defending champion’ tag the biggest challenge for RCB

Kohli headlines a formidable batting unit; uncertainty over the availability of Hazlewood and Dayal a concern in the pace-bowling department

IPL-19 COUNTDOWN

Royal Challengers Bengaluru

OVERALL NUMBERS

M

W

L

NR

271 | 134 | 133 | 4

BY OPPONENT

	M	W	L	NR
CSK	35	13	21	1
DC	33	20	12	1
GT	6	3	3	0
KKR	35	15	20	0
LSG	6	4	2	0
MI	34	15	19	0
PBKS	37	19	18	0
RR	33	17	14	2
SRH	25	11	14	0

Royal Challengers’ remaining matches were against Deccan Chargers (11), GL (5), PWI (5), RPS (4) and KTK (2)

RCB’S 2026 LEAGUE CAMPAIGN*

March 28	vs. SRH	Bengaluru	7.30 p.m.
April 5	vs. CSK	Bengaluru	7.30 p.m.
April 10	vs. RR	Guwahati	7.30 p.m.
April 12	vs. MI	Mumbai	7.30 p.m.

*announced so far

JACOB BETHELL

MIRACLE MAN

Jacob Bethell: A breathtaking 48-ball 105 from Bethell nearly helped England pull off an impossible chase against India in the T20 World Cup semifinal earlier this month. The knock showcased Bethell’s immense value in the shortest format. The 22-year-old played only two games for RCB last season, but the southpaw is primed to lead RCB’s PowerPlay charge this year.

THE SQUAD

Rajat Patidar (Capt.), Jordan Cox, Tim David, Virat Kohli, Devdutt Padikkal, Phil Salt, Jitesh Sharma, Jacob Bethell, Kanishk Chouhan, Venkatesh Iyer, Vihaan Malhotra, Mangesh Yadav, Krunal Pandya, Romario Shepherd, Abhinandan Singh, Satvik Deswal, Jacob Duffy, Josh Hazlewood, Bhuvneshwar Kumar, Vicky Ostwal, Rasikh Salam, Suyash Sharma, Swapnil Singh, Yash Dayal, and Nuwan Thushara.

COMPILED BY G. PRASAD & ASHWIN ACHAL



The King takes strike again: Kohli will look to get going at the top for the Bengaluru outfit. K. MURALI KUMAR

Ashwin Achal

Royal Challengers Bengaluru (RCB) steps into new territory with the start of IPL 2026. Having been the nearly men for the longest period, RCB now enters the arena wearing the coveted tag of ‘defending champion.’

Unsurprisingly, RCB found no good reason to tinker with the proven template which led to the title last season. The majority of the squad has been

retained while there has been a couple of notable inclusions — all-rounder Venkatesh Iyer and pacer Jacob Duffy — from the auction.

Strong middle-order

The side boasts of a powerful batting line-up, capable of maximising friendly home conditions at the M. Chinnaswamy Stadium. The depth in batting poses some welcome selection challenges for the team management.

Fan favourite Virat Kohli

is a shoe-in as opener, with Phil Salt and Jacob Bethell in the race to take up the second slot. Captain Rajat Patidar, Devdutt Padikkal and Tim David form a strong middle-order. Patidar did not find form in the recent domestic season, and needs a quick turnaround when he puts on IPL colours.

It is a toss-up between Padikkal and Venkatesh for a spot in the eleven. Venkatesh does offer an additional bowling option, but with the impact player likely to

be spinner Suyash Sharma, this may not tilt the scales in his favour.

Hometown batter Padikkal, meanwhile, has been in fine form for Karnataka in recent months.

Jitesh’s crucial role

Jitesh Sharma, who came into his own in the previous IPL season, is a crucial presence as finisher and wicketkeeper. Romario Shepherd, Krunal Pandya and David can provide the fireworks in the death overs.

EBFC puts seven past Mohammedan

Amitabha Das Sharma
KOLKATA

East Bengal FC returned to winning ways with a commanding 7-0 victory over a 10-man Mohammedan Sporting Club in their ISL-12 encounter at the Salt Lake Stadium here on Monday.

Mohammedan Sporting struggled to cope with East Bengal’s attacking intensity, and its defensive weaknesses were quickly exposed. The pressure resulted in three penalties as Sporting defenders repeatedly faltered inside the box.

East Bengal moved up to fourth spot with 11 points from six matches while Mohammedan Sporting remained rooted to the bottom without a point.

The result: East Bengal FC 7 (Anwar 7, 78, Ezzejjari 13-pen, 54-pen, Crespo 37-pen, Vishnu 74, Nandhakumar 90+3) bt Mohammedan Sporting 0.

‘I had no option other than pulling out of Candidates’

C. Shyam Sundar
CHENNAI



Humpy isn’t worried about being penalised by FIDE. PTI

India’s top player Koneru Humpy said that she didn’t have an option to explore for competing in the FIDE Women’s Candidates tournament, scheduled in Cyprus from Saturday.

Having made the decision to pull out of the eight-player event on Sunday, Humpy stressed that she had no choice but to do so. “After having prepared so hard for the tournament, it was a tough call. I didn’t have a choice, I had to withdraw,” Humpy, who had safety concerns in the wake of the situation in West Asia given Cyprus’ proximity to the conflict zone, told *The Hindu* on Monday.

“If it was held in some safe country, why would I do that (withdraw)?” the Grandmaster asked, adding that the FIDE could have postponed the tour-

nament. Humpy is unfazed about the possibility of being penalised for choosing not to play in the marquee competition. “I am not worried about fines... they don’t stop me from speaking out or expressing what I feel,” Humpy didn’t mince words.

She said that it wouldn’t be “pleasant” to play an event in West Asia when there is so much happening there. “Many sporting events are getting cancelled. A poker tournament which was supposed to be



The FIDE is the only body which is hosting a tournament now. They are saying that it is safe... that is the problem

held in Cyprus from April 25 has been cancelled. So, it makes sense to postpone it (Candidates). Or if you want to hold it on the exact dates, you have to shift to another country.

“The FIDE is the only body which is hosting a tournament now. They are saying that it is safe... that is the problem,” Humpy, who has been replaced by Anna Muzychuk in the Candidates, said. “Actually, I took time so that I could make the right decision because I know it’s a very important tournament. But at the end of the day, it’s important to take care of my family first.”

Nominees for HI awards announced

Sports Bureau
NEW DELHI

The eighth annual Hockey India awards will be held here on Friday to recognise and reward outstanding performances during the 2025 season.

The nominations were announced on Monday. The men’s team dominated most of the categories except those that had separate sections for men and women, in line with the National team’s performances through the last year. Hardik Singh, Sukhjeet Singh, Sanjay and Abhishek are nominated for male Player-of-the-Year, while Navneet Kaur, Salima Tete, Lalremisiami and Savita Punia will vie for honours in the women’s section.

Hardik, Sukhjeet, Sanjay and Navneet have been nominated in multiple categories. Prince Deep Singh has been nominated for both the goalkeeper and

Upcoming
Player-of-the-Year.

The event will also have special recognitions for Outstanding Achievement and Umpire/Umpire Manager-of-the-Year, among others. Asia Cup-winning men’s team and the bronze medallist Junior men’s team will be felicitated during the function.

The nominees: Player (men): Hardik Singh, Sukhjeet Singh, Sanjay, Abhishek; **Player (women):** Navneet Kaur, Salima Tete, Lalremisiami, Savita Punia; **Goalkeeper:** Prince Deep Singh, Krishan Bahadur Pathak, Bichu Devi Kharibam, Suraj Karkera; **Defender:** Sanjay, Amit Rohidas, Jugraj Singh, Harmanpreet Singh. **Midfielder:** Hardik Singh, Sumit, Raj Kumar Pal, Nilakanta Sharma; **Forward:** Sukhjeet Singh, Abhishek, Navneet Kaur, Shilansand Lakra; **Upcoming Player (men):** Prince Deep Singh, Manmeet Singh, Anmol Ekka, Arshdeep Singh; **Upcoming Player (women):** Sakshi Rana, Jyoti Singh, Sunelita Toppo, Kanika Siwah.



GETTY IMAGES & B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

R. Kaushik

Last year, it was Corbin Bosch, the South African all-rounder. This year, the list has grown longer by one, for now – Blessing Muzarabani, the towering Zimbabwean paceman who had a wonderful T20 World Cup, and Dasun Shanaka, the all-rounder who led Sri Lanka in the same tournament which concluded earlier this month.

We are talking about the late shift of players from the Pakistan Super League to the Indian Premier League. It isn't just a late shift, it's about severing one contract at the last minute to sign a more lucrative deal to be a part of inarguably the most visible franchise-driven T20 competition in the world.

From 2025 onwards, there has been an overlap in dates between the PSL and the IPL. Last year, that was necessitated by Pakistan hosting the Champions Trophy in February-March, though the tournament was also played in Dubai. This year, the PSL had to be postponed from its pre-2025 window owing to the T20 World Cup, which ran in India and Sri Lanka between February 7 and March 8.

The only window available for the Pakistan Cricket Board to conduct the PSL coincided with the IPL; the PSL is due to start this Thursday, two days before the IPL kicks off at the M. Chinnaswamy Stadium with defending champions Royal Challengers Bengaluru locking horns with 2016 winners Sunrisers Hyderabad.

Bosch, part of the Diamond category, had been picked up by Peshawar Zalmi for PSL 2025 before he moved to Mumbai Indians as an injury replacement for fellow South African Lizaad Williams. Understandably miffed at this late 'desertion', the PCB slapped a one-year ban on the now 31-year-old, making him ineligible to play in PSL 2026.

Not that it has made any real difference to the right-arm pacer and hard-hitting batter, considering he is part of the MI roster this year too.

Bosch did it first

Following in Bosch's footsteps are Muzarabani and Shanaka. Muzarabani was one of the standout players for Zimbabwe, who advanced to the Super Eight from a tricky Group B with an unbeaten record. Zimbabwe hadn't even qualified for the previous T20 World Cup, in the Americas in June 2024, but heralded their return to the competition with a stunning victory over Australia in their second group tie.

As if to show that the performance was no flash in the pan, they then subdued the home crowd and Sri Lanka's superstars in their final league clash to top their group and earn a shot at the West Indies, India and South Africa in the next stage.

Muzarabani took four for 17 against Australia, backed it up with two for 38 against the hosts and finished the competition with 13 wickets from just six outings. He was in the running to top the

chart, and it needed the genius of Jasprit Bumrah and a solitary wicket for Varun Chakaravathy in the final for the two Indians to get past him with 14 scalps apiece.

Long before the World Cup, Muzarabani had made a pitch for an IPL berth but went unsold at the auction. He had been a part of the RCB set-up during their title-winning campaign in 2025, signed up as a mid-tournament replacement for the WTC final-bound Lungi Ngidi, but did not play a game. Just as he was readying to extend his relationship with the PSL came a call from the Kolkata Knight Riders management, which sought his services instead of Mustafizur Rahman, the Bangladesh left-arm quick whom they let go in controversial circumstances earlier this year. There was no way Muzarabani was turning that offer down.

Shanaka has moved to Rajasthan Royals as a replacement for Sam Curran, the England all-rounder. In the closed season, Curran was one of two players – Ravindra Jadeja being the other – that five-time champions Chennai Super Kings traded out to Royals to acquire Sanju Samson, who would later go on to become the Player of the Tournament at the T20 World Cup.

Curran played a big part in England's march to the semifinals, but during the course of that campaign, he is learnt to have picked up a groin injury that ended his chances of representing a new IPL franchise.

Shanaka, 34, has limited IPL experience; he played three games for Gujarat Titans in 2023 and was a mid-season substitute for the injured Glenn Phillips last year without getting a match. Like Muzarabani, he too was ignored at the mini-auction ahead of IPL 2026 but a backdoor has opened up through Curran's injury and Shanaka has gratefully grabbed his chance.

Classed as an all-rounder, Shanaka is more of a hard-hitting batter who has been a reluctant bowler; he has a strike-rate of 143.13 in 283 20-over representative games (average 25.83) against 111 wickets, mainly because he averages only 1.2 overs per match.

Strong response expected

Like last year, the PCB hasn't taken kindly to these developments. Its chairman, the irascible Mohsin Naqvi, has again threatened legal action against the 'players who have left'. That the players left at very short notice itself would have been galling; their decision to dump the PSL for the IPL must be particularly infuriating, given the geopolitical tensions between India and Pakistan and the fact that Suryakumar Yadav refused to receive the T20 Asia Cup trophy from Naqvi, who is also the boss of the Asian Cricket Council.

As is often the case in such instances, opinion has been divided on whether Muzarabani and Shanaka this year, and Bosch before him, did the right thing. Their morals have been questioned when what is undeniable is that everyone's

morals are their own outlook and no one else has the right to impose them on someone else.

From the players' perspective, and one is only guessing here, to pass up the chance of being a part of the IPL landscape would have been unthinkable. Without a shadow of doubt, the reach and clout of the IPL are beyond parallel in the cricketing universe. It has opened hitherto invisible doors; its profile is immense, and while the money isn't shabby, it also provides a great opportunity to learn and grow as an individual and a cricketer.

More than just money

The tendency to view the IPL through the prism of financial gains alone is both myopic and convenient. Where else do you have the chance to pick the brains of the best in the business, either occupying the same dressing room or sitting in the opposition dugout? Where else can you savour the experience of playing in front of at least 35,000 spectators? Of learning to cope with noise, pressure and expectations? Of furthering one's education as a cricketer?

It was once said that the English County firmament was the ideal finishing school but that has long passed into history. Admittedly, even till the start of the millennium, a tryst in England at the highest first-class level was an immense learning experience but that is no longer the case.

The IPL has become a finishing school of sorts, and while it is easy to dismiss that remark as facile because it is 'only' a 20-over tournament, let's not forget which format has come to be the flavour of the sport globally. While we can continue to romanticise Test cricket and hope that it survives the very genuine threat of T20 cricket, it is the latter which has caught the imagination of a larger audience.

It's a truism that can't be wished away; gradually, international careers are becoming shorter as more and more professionals are plunging into franchise leagues. Who's to blame them because while we might attach patriotic and nationalist mores, these are players trying their best to eke out a livelihood within the contours of their limited shelf lives.

Muzarabani and Shanaka, and perhaps a couple more who are still expected to make the cross-border move, might use this line of thought to justify their actions though they will also be aware of the risk they run of being called 'mercenaries' by those who hold a divergent point of view. To leave a team, any team, in the lurch at the last minute and therefore not honouring one's word is far from ideal unless the circumstances are pressing and the exit unavoidable.

Those so inclined will argue with justification that there was nothing pressing or unavoidable about their shift

from the PSL to the IPL, and that their decision has been influenced merely by 'greed'. To misquote – for the sake of propriety – a popular saying, opinions are like a nose, everyone has one. And therefore, this is a debate that cannot be settled satisfactorily, one way or the other.

A change on the cards?

Perhaps, the PSL will smell the coffee and revert to its previous timeline that ensured the tournament ran ahead of the IPL and therefore there was no danger of late pullouts and moves to the bigger league. Or maybe it won't if ego comes in the way and the PCB continues to believe in the power of the PSL which, it has said, has become so big, vibrant and productive that the Pakistan board is no longer dependent on the International Cricket Council for financial clout.

The PCB has projected Marnus Labuschagne, Steve Smith and Glenn Maxwell, the Australian trio, as being the overseas poster boys of this edition, arguing that their presence has lifted the profile of the tournament. Maybe it has, but it must not be forgotten that former captain Smith went unsold at the IPL auction or that the underachieving Maxwell, perhaps reading the obvious writing on the wall, chose to not even throw his hat in the ring.

This isn't about which is the bigger, stronger, more influential and powerful league because that is not even a debate. But if one does want to debate the pros and cons of Muzarabani and Shanaka's decisions, they can do so till the cows come home and still not arrive at a satisfactory conclusion. Because that's how it is sometimes.

THE GIST

From 2025 onwards, there has been an overlap in dates between the PSL and the IPL

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New way helps superconductor break temperature record

While superconductivity is easy to achieve at extremely low temperature, bringing it to room temperature is a 'holy grail' of physics; researchers have achieved much higher temperatures in recent years, up to -13 °C, but only by applying pressure equivalent to that near the earth's core

Vasudevan Mukunth
CHENNAI

For more than a century, physicists have looked for a material that conducts electricity with zero resistance at room temperature – practical enough to transform how the world generates and uses energy. But for a long time, the highest temperature at which a material became superconducting at room pressure was -140 °C. Some other materials become superconducting close to room temperature, but only under extraordinary pressure.

In a study published in *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences* on March 9, scientists have reported raising the temperature by 18°C, and under only room pressure. They used a new technique called pressure quenching to achieve this.

The result has broken a record that had stood since 1993, when the same material the team used – a copper oxide called Hg1223 – first demonstrated superconductivity at -140°C, itself a landmark that launched decades of research.

‘Sounds reasonable’

Superconductors that work at room temperature and normal pressure could one day carry electricity through power grids without losing any energy to resistance – a problem that currently wastes billions of dollars’ worth of power every year.

They could also enable faster MRI machines, more efficient electric motors, better transportation systems, and cheaper renewable energy infrastructure.

The team was led by physicists Liangzi Deng and Ching-Wu Chu at the University of Houston.

“The claim sounds reasonable to me,” aid Sumit Mazumdar, professor of physics, chemistry, and optical sciences at the University of Arizona, in an email to *The Hindu*.

“The authors carefully study high-pressure structures, and when they find first order transitions (which involves latent heat), they do what they call pressure-quenching so that the changed high pressure structure persists even when the pressure is removed,” he added.

Intense pressure

Since 1993, the record for ambient pressure superconductivity has been stuck at -140 °C. While superconductivity is easy to achieve at extremely low temperature, bringing it to room temperature is a “holy grail” of physics.

Researchers have achieved much higher temperatures in recent years, up to -13 °C, but only by applying pressure equivalent to that near the earth’s core.

These high-pressure states have also disappeared the moment the pressure was released, making them useless for practical technologies like lossless power grids or high-speed trains.

The problem was not that scientists lacked the materials. Under extreme pressure, Hg1223 itself superconducts at -109 °C .

Some compounds rich in hydrogen have also shown hints of becoming superconductors at near room temperature. But they have all required intense pressure as well.

Reproducible data

The Houston team’s insight was to stop looking for new materials and to focus on preserving a known high-pressure state in Hg1223.

For this, the scientists developed the pressure-quench protocol (PQP) – a three-stage process designed to freeze a high-pressure superconducting state in place by removing pressure fast enough and at a low enough temperature.

They loaded a small crystal of Hg1223 into a diamond anvil cell and compressed it to up to 30 billion pascals (GPa), raising its superconducting temperature to over -123°C , while keeping track of its superconducting properties. Then they cooled the sample to -269 °C , just above absolute zero.

Finally, they rapidly released the pressure. Because the material was so cold, the atoms lacked the energy to relax back into their normal structure, effectively trapping the material’s desirable electronic properties at the normal atmospheric pressure.

Across five tests with different pressures and quenching conditions, the team consistently retained the transition temperature between -122 °C and -134 °C. They achieved the higher -122 °C by quenching from approximately 19 GPa at



Ching-Wu Chu holds a diamond anvil cell in a University of Houston lab. UNIVERSITY OF HOUSTON

-269 °C. They could also reproduce it, a sign that it is likely real rather than an artifact in the data.

The 122 °C reading is 18 °C higher than the previous record held by the same material in its relaxed state.

The scientists also used synchrotron X-ray diffraction at the U.S. Argonne National Laboratory to find that while the material retained its original crystal structure after quenching, there were new defects in the structure and additional internal strain.

These defects helped lock the crystal into a state where it mimicked the effects of pressure even after the pressure was removed. The team confirmed that roughly 78% of the material’s volume became superconducting, so it wasn’t a surface or filamentary effect.

If superconductivity is filamentary, it means electricity is only traveling through microscopic channels, called filaments, within the material. These filaments can only carry a very small amount of electrical current before they break and return to a normal state.

If the bulk is superconducting, as the researchers reported, the material can be expected to reliably carry large currents, which is required to transport power on run high-speed trains.

The quenched phase was stable for at least three days when stored in liquid nitrogen. Warming above -73 °C reduced the effect while room temperature (23 °C) partially reversed it. One experiment also produced a hint of superconductivity at -101 °C but the team wasn’t able to reproduce it.

‘Woodstock of physics’

The study’s lead investigator, Ching-Wu Chu, is a pioneer of high-temperature superconductivity. In 1987, Prof. Chu and his team made a landmark discovery when they synthesised a material called yttrium barium copper oxide (YBCO) that became a superconductor at -180 °C.

Until then, scientists only had materials that became superconducting below -269 °C, which meant they had to be cooled using expensive liquid helium.

However, -180 °C was above the boiling point of liquid nitrogen (-196 °C), which meant scientists could cool YBCO using this much cheaper coolant, paving the way for more research and potential applications.

That same year, the American Physical Society held a special session on high-temperature superconductivity that ran past midnight and drew thousands of attendees – an event that has since been called the ‘Woodstock of physics’. Prof. Chu was one of the central figures there and presented his team’s results to a



The method, if it works out in other cases, has great promise for a room-pressure superconductor. Not yet for room-temperature. The latter is not essential for technological applications

SUMIT MAZUMDAR
Professor at the University of Arizona

packed and electrified audience. The session captured the excitement of a field that, in that moment, seemed to be on the edge of transforming technology.

His work earned him numerous honours, including the National Medal of Science in 1994.

Now, beyond breaking a 33-year-old record, according to the new study’s authors, their work may also open the door for scientists to ‘stabilise’ exotic electronic properties in other materials that arise under pressure and make them available at ordinary conditions.

“The method, if it works out in other cases, has great promise for a room-pressure superconductor. Not yet for room-temperature,” according to Prof. Mazumdar. “The latter is not essential for technological applications. The entire issue therefore revolves around what the authors call pressure-quenching [and] whether structural changes that occur under pressure can really be retained post-quenching.”

He added that while this issue is beyond his expertise, it is not impossible.

“This result will be widely noted in the superconductivity community, and I expect that many experimentalist groups will apply the same methodology to other candidate materials,” Brookhaven National Laboratory, New York, physicist Ivan Božović, who wasn’t involved in the study but reviewed it for the journal, told *Physics*.

The paper’s authors themselves wrote: “We ... believe that the record-breaking results at ambient pressure reported here represent only the beginning of an extremely fruitful scientific journey.”

Recent controversies

High-temperature superconductivity research has been shadowed by controversy for much of the past decade and understanding that backdrop has come to matter when evaluating new claims in the field.

These episodes have made the research community acutely sensitive to the claims of new studies, particularly whether a given material’s resistance can really drop to zero – the hallmark of

superconductivity – and if the data showing that is because the instruments are actually measuring the sample.

The most prominent case involved Ranga Dias at the University of Rochester in the U.S. Dias published papers claiming room-temperature superconductivity in carbonaceous sulphur hydrides in 2020 and nitrogen-doped lutetium hydrides in 2023. Dias and his team retracted both papers, published in *Nature*, after allegations that the magnetic susceptibility measurements had been manipulated to show signs of superconductivity.

Multiple independent labs also failed to reproduce the findings. Dias contested the retractions and the dispute has already become one of the most acrimonious data-integrity controversies in physics.

In 2023, a group of researchers from South Korea said they had made a lead-based material called LK-99 that was a superconductor at room-pressure and room-temperature.

The result generated intense public interest but soon, other scientists who recreated the experiment couldn’t find signs of superconductivity in LK-99.

Later studies revealed that some of the measurements the South Korean team had made were ‘polluted’ by unexpected ferromagnetic behaviour in LK-99.

The episode further exhausted the public appetite for superconductivity news.

‘Decades-old reputation’

Both Dias’s work and the new University of Houston study use diamond anvil cells. However, unlike the materials in Dias’s work, Hg1223 is well-understood and has a record going back to the 1980s.

The team also focused on a unique state of the material – one that arises under intense pressure – rather than claim a new phase, experts said.

The study also directly addressed the primary criticism of the Dias episode: whether superconductivity is a bulk property or filamentary.

As noted earlier, the team found that some 78% of the material was superconducting. Dias and others didn’t perform these tests.

“The dubious claims ... came from people who were practically unknown prior to their claims of novelty,” Prof. Mazumdar said. “The principal author Chu in this case came close to winning the Nobel Prize [and] is the recipient of the US National Medal of Science. His current paper’s ref. 22 goes back to 1968.

“He is not going to risk his decades-old reputation writing fraudulent stuff.” mukunth.v@thehindu.co.in



A Hudsonian godwit in the Monomoy National Wildlife Refuge, Massachusetts, U.S. AFP

Hope builds for nations to save bird that flies 30,000 km

Agence France-Presse

Chasing an endless summer, one shorebird species undertakes a gruelling annual journey from the Arctic to the tip of South America and back -- a feat increasingly fraught with peril.

The Hudsonian godwit (*Limosa haemastica*) is one of the world’s most remarkable travellers, but its population has plunged 95% in four decades due to a complex mix of environmental changes across multiple countries.

It is one of 42 species proposed for international protection at a meeting of parties to the UN Convention on the Conservation of Migratory Species (CMS) that starts in Brazil on March 23.

Iconic creatures like the snowy owl -- of *Harry Potter* fame -- striped hyena and hammerhead shark are also on the list deemed in danger of extinction and needing conservation by the countries they pass through.

The Hudsonian godwit (*Limosa haemastica*) is one of the world’s most remarkable travellers, but its population has plunged 95% in four decades due to a complex mix of environmental changes

Migratory birds are facing "rapid and dramatic declines," said Nathan Senner, an ecologist and ornithology professor at the University of Massachusetts Amherst who has studied the Hudsonian godwit for 20 years.

Scientists are still unravelling the mysteries of the shorebird, which can fly up to 11,000 km in one stretch without stopping to eat, drink or sleep.

And it is only part of the 30,000 km that the godwit travels every year from their breeding grounds in the Arctic to Patagonia where they spend the southern summer.

In order to do this "epic flight," they need "really predictable, abundant food resources" at every step of the journey, Senner told *AFP*.

That predictability is crumbling. In the Arctic, shifting spring timing attributed to climate change has created a mismatch between when chicks hatch and the peak availability of insects they feed on.

One of the puzzles Senner is currently working on is why Hudsonian godwits have begun migrating later by six days than they did a decade ago.

Something "has either disrupted the cues that they use to time their migrations or their ability to successfully and rapidly prepare for the migration," he said.

In southern Chile, a boom in salmon and oyster farming has led to a build-up of infrastructure and the presence of people in the intertidal zones where they feed. And in the United States, changes in farming practices are making the shallow water wetlands that the godwits rely on rarer and less predictable -- meaning they spend more time looking for a place to stop and feed.

"I think that is emblematic of lots of species, that most species can respond to one kind of change, but not a whole bunch of them all at the same time," said Senner.

"Climate change is taking a heavy toll on species that rely on a 'geological clock' for their survival; many are disappearing," Rodrigo Agostinho, president of Brazil's environmental agency (Ibama) said.

These are some of the issues CMS parties will tackle at their meeting in Brazil's biodiversity-rich Pantanal, one of the world's most important global meetings for wildlife conservation.

These countries are legally obliged to protect species listed as at risk of extinction, conserve and restore their habitats, prevent obstacles to migration and cooperate with other range states.



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